

Conversations

Engaging in Spiritual Dialogue
with God and Others

By

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Unless otherwise noted, all scripture references are from the New International Version (NIV).

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Introduction *by Hazen*

Before there were sermons or songs, before mountains rose or oceans stirred, there was a voice. And it spoke not in isolation but in perfect unity.

Father, Son, and Spirit—one God in eternal communion. Their words formed the heavens, shaped the earth, and spun galaxies into motion. At the center of all things was conversation. Not noise. Not power. But love. Shared aloud.

And then, astonishingly, we were made—not merely to observe that conversation, *but to enter it.*

This book is about that invitation into conversation. About prayer, yes—but also about every sacred moment when doorways for relationship and silence becomes a space for growing awareness of Holy presence. It's about learning to hear the voice of God in whispered prayers, in shared tears, in Scripture, in jubilant dance, in restful silence, and even in the voices of one another.

Prayer is the heartbeat of divine dialogue. But conversations with friends, mentors, family—even strangers—can carry echoes of the same eternal rhythm. When we speak with kindness, listen with

intention, or confess with courage, we align ourselves with the very nature of God who is always speaking and always drawing near.

Throughout this book, we'll explore:

- How the Trinity models relational, transformative, and loving communication.
- How prayer forms and transforms us, not just in solitude, but in community.
- How divine conversations in relationships shape our identity, sustain us in suffering, heal the wounds of our soul, and bind us together in unity.
- How everyday conversations can become sacred spaces to share the grace for eternal life.

This isn't just a book about saying prayers. It's about becoming a person of communion and community. Someone who listens deeply. Speaks honestly. And walks with God not only in quiet places but in the shared space of daily life.

So come close.

Let your heart be opened.

Let your words find their way into the ongoing conversation that has always been—and always will be.

Let the sacred conversation begin:

Whether you are new to a relationship with God or have been walking with Him for years, there is always more to discover in the realm of divine conversation. My hope is that, as you read, you will begin to recognize the many ways God is already speaking to you. That you will see prayer not as an obligation but as the most natural and transformative conversation you could ever have. And that, ultimately, your life will be marked by an ongoing, vibrant dialogue with the One who knows and loves you most. That you grow in conversation with those around you in a way that draws everyone your life touches closer to their Maker.

And in this journey, we won't be walking alone. My wife, Hannah, will be joining me as a co-contributor to this book. With a master's degree in spiritual formation and a calling as a spiritual director, Hannah brings the wisdom of the mystics and the attentiveness of a true soul scientist into every reflection. This is our first project together and, throughout these pages, we'll alternate voices weaving in our own stories, insights, and perspectives. In many ways, this book is a roundtable conversation—between Hannah and myself, between us and God, and between all of us and you. We pray it draws you deeper into the divine dialogue that is always unfolding.

A Prayer to Begin:

Father, Son, and Holy Spirit—

You who have always been in communion,
speaking in love before time began,
thank you for inviting me into Your eternal conversation.

Quiet my heart.

Still the noise within and around me, calm my anxious thoughts,
that I may hear Your voice—not only in sacred spaces, but in the
ordinary rhythms of my day.

I enter into peace only you can give.

Teach me to listen with attentiveness.

To speak with faith believing you are listening.

At moments to pause with reverence to see your beauty.

I want to experience You not only in my prayer closets
but among others in heartfelt words, shared meals, hard questions,
and holy shared silences.

May this book become more than words on a page.

May it become an altar—where I offer myself in worship as dialogue
is rekindled And communion deepens.

Teach me again what it means to walk with You

in every word and every moment. Help me practice your presence at all times and in all things.

Form me into someone who prays without ceasing,
not just with words,
but with a life attuned to You.

Draw me close
and let your sacred conversations begin to swirl and surround my life
and relationships.

Amen.

Chapter 1: The Trinity Talks

by Hannah

The Conversation at the Center of the Universe

Before anything was, there was only the vast, formless void. A silence beyond imagination stretched across the infinite expanse. No stars blinked. No earth turned. No sound stirred the darkness. It was deep and thick like a velvet shroud, eternal and still.

And then—hovering over the chaotic waters like a poised artist awaiting the first stroke—the Spirit of God moved (Genesis 1:2). His presence was not anxious but expectant. In the sacred stillness, the triune God prepared to speak beauty into being.

The Father opened His mouth, and His voice broke the void like thunder. Yet, His tone wrapped in tenderness.

From Him came the Word—the eternal Logos, radiant and alive, Christ pre-incarnate (John 1:1). The Spirit responded, dancing with the Word, sweeping across the deep, stirring light into existence with every movement.

Creation did not erupt from chaos but from communion. It was no accident, but a masterpiece born of love. Proverbs 8 portrays Wisdom—commonly linked to Christ—as rejoicing beside the Father, daily His delight, "playing before Him at all times, rejoicing in His inhabited world and delighting in mankind."

Their conversation birthed galaxies, two trillion of them. Their unity framed mountains. Their joy spilled into oceans, forests, and fields. The chorus of creation begins not with noise, but with conversation—the eternal, intimate dialogue of the Trinity.

In truth, the very cornerstone of creation was conversation. The world was not formed from silence alone, but from speech; not from power alone, but from relationship. The Trinity did not merely act—they communed. They delighted. They shared. From the overflow of that eternal exchange of love and intention came the cosmos.

As the poet Luci Shaw writes:

"From the emptiness of dark
He spoke
and galaxies spun out in spiraled flame."

This vastness can at times be hard to fathom, yet we believe our triune God created it all. This illustration can help us try to grasp this vastness: Try to imagine every grain of sand on every beach

on Earth. Now imagine that each grain represents a galaxy. That's how many galaxies exist in the observable universe alone—about 2 trillion.

And then, at the crescendo of this divine creative power bringing all things into existence, the triune God declares, "Let us make human beings in our image, to be like us" (Genesis 1:26, New Living Translation). Male and female are not merely created—they are invited into a unique relationship. One fashioned from love, for love: a community that mirrors the very nature of God. The Trinity decided we were made to be like them.

The foundation of their communion is communication, and so it is with us. We, as bearers of the *imago Dei* (the image of God), are unique in all creation. Like our triune Creator, our words carry creative power. As Proverbs reminds us, "Life and death are in the power of the tongue..." (Proverbs 18:21, Holman Christian Standard Bible). Through our words—spoken or silent, sung or prayed—we participate in the divine rhythm of creating, relating, and loving.

From our image bearing essence flows humanity's highest calling: to live in communion with God and to reflect His relational, creative love to one another. We are made to love and to be loved. This is not a distant or abstract truth. It's personal. It's an invitation to live a certain way: leaning into love.

When we understand how the Trinity communicates, we begin to reimagine our own relationship with God—and with each other. At the center of all creation is not power, control, or fear but loving communion. From this eternal relationship flows the very heartbeat of prayer, unity, and ever deepening relationship.

When I was studying spiritual formation, one of my gracious professors led us into a sacred reflection—an invitation to imagine ourselves at the table of conversation with the Trinity. She guided us into this moment with a piece of art drawn from the heart of Christian tradition: *The Holy Trinity* by Andrei Rublev.

In the icon, three radiant figures sit around a table in serene fellowship, halos crowning their heads. The perspective of the image opens gently outward—as if extending an invitation to the viewer. Come. Take your place. Join the eternal dialogue.

She dismissed us for a time of silent reflection. What were these divine beings speaking about? How did they feel about my presence there? Was there something I might dare to say, to offer, to ask?

As I sat in silence, eyes fixed on the image before me, something holy stirred. I felt the *Welcome*. The *Joy*. The *Life*. I felt young in the presence of Eternity—yet not out of place. I was invited to lean in and listen, to behold and to begin to understand. I was drawn into

their communion to glean and grow, to be fashioned and formed by the beauty of their bond.

And, in time, to ask questions.

I was loved. I was welcomed. I had a seat at the Table of the Trinity.

One of C.S. Lewis's most well-known reflections on the Trinity comes from Mere Christianity. Here's the quote:

“All sorts of people are fond of repeating the Christian statement that ‘God is love.’ But they seem not to notice that the words ‘God is love’ have no real meaning unless God contains at least two Persons. Love is something that one person has for another person. If God was a single person, then before the world was made, He was not love.”

The Divine Dance

The early Church described the Trinity with the word *perichoresis*—a mutual indwelling, a circle of love so intimate and dynamic it could only be described as a dance. But this is no polite waltz. It is more like a whirling dervish—spinning with passion, rhythm, and holy fire. Each Person of the Trinity moves in perfect synchrony with the others, not losing their distinction, but delighting in their oneness.

This divine dance is not for spectators. It is an open circle. The hands of Father, Son, and Spirit reach out to us, inviting us in—not to observe, but to join. As they whirl in eternal joy and mutual self-giving, we are swept into the movement. To pray is not simply to speak—it is to move with God. To worship is not merely to sing—it is to enter the spin of divine delight.

This rhythm is not mechanical; it is mystical. It is the Spirit drawing us near, the Son leading us in, the Father welcoming us home.

And here is the mystery of all mysteries: through the incarnation, Jesus did not take on the form of a cosmic force or celestial being—He became human. Flesh and blood. He entered our world not as an angel or a supernova or an alien lifeform, but as one of us. By becoming forever human, Jesus brought humanity into the heart of God. Through faith, we are now joined to Christ by the Spirit, and in Him, we are welcomed into the sacred fellowship of the Trinity.

This invitation is not extended to angels, nor to any other created being in the same way. We—redeemed, embodied humans—are drawn into the circle of divine love, not as guests but as family. We are swept into the spinning grace of the Godhead, caught up in the rhythm of eternal joy. This is the miracle of union with Christ: that we are seated with Him in heavenly places (Ephesians 2:6), participating in the conversation that has echoed from eternity past.

To be in Christ is to belong to this holy communion, to move with the music of divine love, and to know that we were made—not to watch from the edge—but to join the dance. As we yield to the tempo of God's love, we find ourselves caught up in the motion of heaven. The more we surrender, the more in step we become. The more we listen, the more we hear the heartbeat of divine communion.

To pray is to step into rhythm.

To listen is to follow the beat.

To respond is to dance with God.

The Trinity talks—and invites us to join the conversation.

In the hush before the world was formed,
the Word was spoken, not alone.
Three voices, one eternal tone—
a harmony that shaped the stone.

The dance began before the dawn,
the Spirit whirled, the Father drew,
the Son stepped forth in light and flame,
and made a space for me and you.

Not angels, stars, nor blazing suns
were summoned to the inner ring,

but dust, now clothed in mercy's robe,
to share the joy of everything.

So now we move, not just to pray,
but answer love with every breath—
caught in the rhythm of the Three,
whose life has danced through death.

We are not called to monologue but to mutuality. Not just to discipline, but to delight.

Not only to ask, but to abide.

This dialogue is not reserved for mystics—it's the inheritance of all who believe. Through Christ, by the Spirit, to the Father, we enter a communion older than time itself. When we join the Trinity in this holy conversation, prayer becomes more than a duty. It becomes a dance. A dialogue. A source of joy. A taste of heaven on earth.

Conclusion: When the Lion Sang

One of my favorite scenes in all of literature takes place not in a temple or on a mountaintop—but in a silent void, where a Lion begins to sing.

In *The Magician's Nephew*, C.S. Lewis gives us a window into creation, not just as an event, but as an act of communion. In the

darkness, the characters stand on the edge of a formless land—empty, still, waiting. And then it begins.

“In the darkness something was happening at last. A voice had begun to sing... It was very beautiful.”

It’s Aslan’s voice—deep, golden, overflowing with joy. And as the song rises, creation answers. Grass sprouts. Stars appear. The sun breaks the horizon.

“The Voice was suddenly joined by other voices; more voices than you could possibly count... It was the stars. The First Voice had made them appear... and now they made music too.”

It’s not just majestic—it’s relational. Creation unfolds in harmony. Not a command barked into being, but a melody sung in love. The Lion doesn’t merely *speak*—He sings. And the world sings back.

“The Lion was pacing to and fro about that empty land and singing his new song. It was softer and more lilting... and as he walked and sang the valley grew green with grass.”

That image—of Aslan singing a world into being—feels like a parable of Genesis 1. It draws us into the mystery of the Trinity. The Father dreams, the Word speaks, the Spirit moves—and out of that

eternal, loving conversation, creation begins. Not from isolation, but from relationship. Not from power alone, but from delight.

This is the kind of God we meet in Scripture. A God who sings stars into the sky. A God who creates not because He must, but because love overflows. A God who has never stopped speaking.

And that same Voice still speaks today. The song continues.

There's a haunting moment in Lewis's scene where Uncle Andrew, hardened by pride and fear, hears the same song—but refuses to receive it. Lewis writes:

“Now the trouble about trying to make yourself stupider than you really are is that you very often succeed.”

Where others hear music, he hears noise. The invitation to communion is there—but he chooses control instead. And it reminds me: the Trinity is always speaking. The question is, *are we listening?*

This book—this journey—is an invitation to listen again. To press your ear toward the harmony that has always been singing: Father, Son, and Spirit in eternal, joyful communion.

Prayer is not the start of that conversation. It is our joining of one already in progress. And like Digory and Lucy, standing in awe at the Lion's song, we are invited not to spectate, but to step in.

So as we move forward—chapter by chapter, prayer by prayer—may we tune our hearts to hear the song. The world was made by it. We were made for it. And the Voice that sang stars into flame now calls your name.

Let us listen. Let us respond. Let us walk into this holy conversation where everything begins.

“This was the most magical sound in the world... it was beyond comparison, the most beautiful noise he had ever heard. It was so beautiful he could hardly bear it.”

—*The Magician's Nephew*, C.S. Lewis

In the following chapter, we'll explore moments in Scripture where this same divine conversation—so beautifully echoed in the Lion's song—breaks into our world. These glimpses of inter-Trinitarian dialogue invite us not only to listen, but to live in ongoing communion with our Holy Triune God.

Chapter 2: When God Speaks to God

by Hannah

One of the first gifts God gave humanity was a voice—not just to name animals or to declare needs but to know and to be known. The first human words recorded in Scripture are not prayers or proclamations, but the poetic words of a husband looking upon his wife. Adam beholds Eve and speaks not with utility, but with wonder: *“At last!”* he says, *“This one is bone from my bone, and flesh from my flesh.”*

Before the rupture of the first sin, before its subsequent shame, there was holy speech among God and among humans. Honest, unfiltered, face-to-face speech—between Adam and Eve, and between them and God. That sacred rhythm of conversation was meant to flow in two directions: vertically and horizontally. Love exchanged with God was meant to overflow in love exchanged with one another. The first conversations between humans weren’t transactional, they were relational. They were intimate. Vulnerable. Exclamatory. And they were designed to reflect the inner life of the Trinity—where words are not tools of control but expressions of love, honor, delight, and presence.

Hazen and I have been married long enough now to know that holy conversation between husband and wife doesn't always look poetic. Sometimes, it's raw. It's heavy. Sometimes it's about scheduling logistics like who's picking up the kids or why the tone was off in the kitchen that morning. Sometimes it's a confession. Sometimes it's silence. Sometimes it's laughter late at night that heals the ache of everything that came before.

But in all of it—the messy and the beautiful—there's this stubborn rhythm of return. We circle back. We stay in it. We learn to keep talking, even when it's hard. That, I think, is a glimpse into what God wants with us. Not perfection. Not polish. But presence. Ongoing, honest, sometimes awkward but always sacred connection. Marriage, in all its complexity, is a window—a fragile, flawed, but Spirit-filled picture of the deeper dialogue we were made for.

In the same way that I want to be known and loved by Hazen in all my contradictions—strong and tired, joyful and burdened, fierce and fragile—I believe God desires that kind of vulnerable, real communion with us. That's what this chapter—and this book—is about.

The Trinity talks.

And we were made to join the conversation.

Divine Dialogue in Affirmation

The Gospels and Epistles offer us breathtaking glimpses into the ongoing conversation between Father, Son, and Holy Spirit. These moments not only reveal the heart of God, but shape the contours of our own spiritual life.

Take, for example, the baptism of Jesus—a stunning moment where the Trinity is fully revealed in harmonious motion. The heavens open, the Spirit descends like a dove, and the Father's voice echoes from above: "This is my dearly loved Son, who brings me great joy" (Matthew 3:17, NLT). The Son stands in the water, humbly submitting to the Father's will. The Spirit hovers, affirming and empowering. And the Father speaks, full of delight.

Remarkably, every time we hear the audible voice of God in the Gospels, it is in affirmation of the Son. This occurs at Jesus' baptism (Matthew 3:17), again at the transfiguration where the Father says, "This is my dearly loved Son, who brings me great joy. Listen to him" (Matthew 17:5, NLT), and once more as Jesus approaches the cross, when the Father declares, "I have already brought glory to my name, and I will do so again" (John 12:28, NLT). In each moment, the divine voice is not one of rebuke or distance, but of profound affection and approval. The Father speaks with joy over the Son and, in doing so, reveals His heart not just for Jesus but for all who are in Him.

In many ways, this moment of Jesus' initiation into the fullness of the Holy Spirit was another beautiful expression of the Trinity's relational rhythm—conversing, creating, and commissioning together. Just as the Spirit hovered over the waters in Genesis and the Word came forth from the Father here, again, we see the Trinity moving in perfect unity: the Son ready in obedience, the Spirit descending with power, and the Father speaking identity and delight.

It is not only a moment of anointing—it is a moment of co-creating. Heaven and earth meet in the waters of the Jordan, as divine communion overflows into redemptive purpose. This is divine conversation incarnated—sacred speech and movement echoing the eternal rhythm of relationship that shaped the cosmos itself.

Far more than a starting point for public ministry, this baptism is a mirror of eternal love. Each Person of the Trinity is fully present, fully engaged, and fully giving. The Son beloved. The Spirit descending. The Father delighting. It is a living icon of divine fellowship—a sacred window into the conversation that has always been and now invites us in. In this moment of glorious unity, we are reminded that all of God's actions are born from communion and point us back to relationship.

There was a season in my life when I was coming out from under false authorities—shedding the improper influence I had given

others. More than anything, I needed the affirming voice of the Father—to name me, to declare my worth and value in a way that was undeniable and irreplaceable.

For weeks, every Sunday, I would sit beneath an oak tree outside my church and pray Ephesians 3:14: “For this reason I bend my knees before the Father, from whom every family in heaven and on earth derives its name.” If the families of heaven and earth were named by the Father, maybe He could name me too.

In the quiet, as I stilled my soul and opened my heart—strong enough only to wait—I felt a slow, deep shift. Beyond words, the Father blessed me. His love and value began to gently seep into my heart, releasing me into who I truly was.

And in that sacred naming, I realized I wasn’t just being healed—I was being invited into the eternal conversation of the Trinity, where love speaks, listens, and never stops calling us by name.

Divine Dialogue in Temptation

Then, immediately following this sacred unveiling, the Spirit leads Christ into the wilderness to be tested (Matthew 4:1). The same Spirit who descended with power now guides with purpose, not into comfort, but into confrontation. The wilderness becomes the

proving ground of obedience, a crucible where identity, trust, and truth are refined. And yet even here, the divine dialogue continues.

There is a profound parallel to the Garden of Eden. In that original paradise, the serpent whispered his famous question: "Did God really say...?" (Genesis 3:1, NLT). His aim was, and still is, to undermine our trust in the voice of God. Adam and Eve, well-fed and surrounded by beauty, chose to doubt God's word and to embrace the lie. In contrast, Jesus, famished after forty days of fasting, weary in His flesh, is confronted with the same temptation. But He clings to the voice of the Father. When the accuser taunts, Jesus answers, "It is written..."

He does not lean on emotion, circumstance, or human reasoning—He stands on Scripture. "Man shall not live on bread alone, but on every word that comes from the mouth of God" (Matthew 4:4, New International Version). Where Adam fell in a garden of abundance, Jesus stood firm in a wilderness of lack. Where our first parents doubted the goodness of God's voice, Jesus trusted it completely.

This is our path as well. To follow Jesus is to walk into wildernesses of testing with the Spirit as our guide, and the Word as our anchor. The divine dialogue does not only shape sacred moments of blessing—it steadies us in the desert places of trial. And in each

testing, we are given the chance to rewrite the story our ancestors got wrong.

Our life is not just formed by whose voice we trust but also by how we handle the conversation with the accuser—whose voice is present whether in the garden or the wilderness. Will we, like Adam and Eve, allow doubt to distort the voice of God? Or will we, like Jesus, stand in the silence and hunger, and hold fast to the truth: "It is written"? The difference between ruin and redemption often lies in how we respond when the deceiver speaks. In these moments, we are invited to echo back the Word that gives life—to trust, to obey, and to join the Son in faithful conversation with the Father.

An accusation the enemy has often echoed in my mind is the lie that I don't belong. I've felt it in public places, in rooms full of confident women, or in large groups where joy flows easily and everyone seems comfortable in their own skin. That strange dissociation creeps in—the discomfort in my own body, the ache of feeling out of place, the urge to run and hide.

It's real. And it shows up right at the crossroads of my desire to be present, to be known, and to live authentically in community.

But how I respond in those moments makes all the difference.

I can't give in to the lie and shrink back into isolation. I must choose, again and again, to lay hold of the truth of who God says I

am. To anchor myself not in my own insecurity, but in His unwavering affirmation.

Because I do belong—I belong to Him. And He has named me, called me, and placed me within His family. Even in moments of trembling, I am part of the fellowship of the Trinity, invited into the love that forever flows between the Father, Son, and Spirit. In that love, I find my place—and I am home.

Divine Dialogue in Intercession

The conversation of the Trinity is not confined to moments of affirmation, testing, or suffering. It also continues in unseen groanings and heavenly petitions. Divine dialogue takes the form of intercession—Christ before the Father, and the Spirit within us.

Romans 8:26 tells us, “The Holy Spirit helps us in our weakness. For example, we don’t know what God wants us to pray for. But the Holy Spirit prays for us with groanings that cannot be expressed in words” (NLT). These aren’t idle sighs—they are sacred utterances, Spirit-breathed appeals aligned with the Father’s heart. When we are speechless in our pain or confusion, the Spirit is not. He meets us in our frailty and prays with power and precision.

We even see this kind of sacred groaning in the life of Jesus. Just before raising Lazarus from the dead, Jesus was “deeply moved in

spirit and troubled” (John 11:33, NIV) and He “groaned within Himself” (John 11:38, A Faithful Version). This was more than human emotion—it was divine compassion stirred by grief, injustice, and the burden of death itself. His inner groaning reveals the intensity of love and the weight of intercession carried in His heart. Even in that moment, the Son was communing with the Father in silent, holy anguish—a divine dialogue at the edge of resurrection.

Hebrews 7:25 reminds us that Jesus “lives forever to intercede with God on [our] behalf” (NLT). The Son, risen and reigning, did not retire from ministry—He speaks continually to the Father for us. His intercession is not occasional; it is eternal. The conversation between Father and Son has never ceased, and now we are its subject.

One of the clearest and most beautiful pictures of this intercession is found in John 17, often called Jesus’ High Priestly Prayer. On the night before His crucifixion, Jesus lifts His eyes to heaven and begins to pray for His disciples and for all who would believe through their message. In this moment, we are drawn into the sacred intimacy of the Son speaking to the Father.

Four times in this prayer, Jesus asks that His followers “may be one” just as He and the Father are one (John 17:11, 21–23). This repeated plea reveals the longing of His heart, not merely for outward harmony, but for deep, spiritual unity rooted in Trinitarian love. His

intercession reaches across time and space: drawing the global Church into the eternal conversation of oneness.

This intercessory dialogue within the Trinity assures us that we are never alone in prayer. Even when our prayers feel weak or hollow, we are not the only ones speaking. The Spirit groans. The Son advocates. The Father listens. This is the divine conversation of intercession—and it surrounds us always.

The Spirit does not wait for eloquence. He steps into our confusion and weakness with power and compassion. Romans 8:26 reminds us, “The Holy Spirit helps us in our weakness...the Spirit pleads for us believers in harmony with God’s own will” (NLT). He takes our sighs, our groans, our wordless longings, and carries them into the presence of the Father. In those quiet, aching spaces where we cannot find words, the Spirit forms our silence into sacred communion.

Even in prayer, we are never alone—the Trinity is present, attentive, and already speaking on our behalf. From these divine exchanges, we learn that prayer is not a cold ritual but a warm room: always inhabited and always alive with love.

There have been seasons in my life where I’ve sat down to pray and found nothing but silence in me—no words, no clarity, just need. But in those moments, I’ve come to trust that God is still speaking.

Not everything needs to be said by me. Sometimes the most sacred prayers are the ones I never say out loud, the ones the Spirit shapes and delivers in groans and breath and presence.

If you find yourself weary, wordless, or unsure how to pray—take heart. You’re not failing. You’re being carried. Prayer is not something you muster up; it’s a conversation you’re invited into. Let the Spirit pray in you. Let Jesus speak over you. And let the Father receive you in love. You are not alone in the quiet. You are not unheard.

You are in the room where Love speaks.

Divine Dialogue in Suffering

In the Garden of Gethsemane, Jesus cries out to the Father, “If it is possible, let this cup of suffering be taken away from me. Yet I want your will to be done, not mine” (Matthew 26:39, NLT). Here we see that divine dialogue does not exclude agony or honesty. The vulnerability of Jesus becomes a model for us: prayer is not performance, but participation in a relationship marked by trust. In this anguished appeal, the Son surrenders His will to the Father’s—fully aware of the cost, yet fully committed to obedience. The garden becomes sacred ground where divine love meets human fear, and faith is refined in sorrow.

On the cross, Jesus utters the haunting words, “My God, my God, why have you abandoned me?” (Matthew 27:46, NLT). In that moment, tragically, for the first time since eternity past, the Father’s response is silence. The Son, clothed in the sin of the world, is plunged into the desolation of divine judgment. The perfect communion of the Trinity is not broken, but mysteriously veiled, as the holy wrath of God—righteous and just—is poured out not on creation, but on Himself. The holy rage of God turns inward, absorbing the punishment of our rebellion so that we might be embraced in grace.

This is no theological rupture, as if the cross were the result of a divine disagreement or a feud within the Trinity. Rather, it is the most profound act of divine love—a self-giving exchange within the Godhead that rewrites the story of humanity. In this moment, the Son willingly bears the weight of sin, the Father gives His Beloved, and the Spirit sustains the suffering Christ through the agony. This act of surrender is not the breaking of unity, but the revelation of its depth. The Trinity is not torn apart at Calvary; it is revealed in its fullness—justice satisfied, mercy extended, and love poured out without measure. Through this mysterious silence, the conversation of heaven opens wide to include us.

At the cross, divine justice and divine mercy meet in a silence louder than thunder, where the punishment we deserved is absorbed by the only One who never deserved it. This is love beyond

comprehension: the eternal Son bearing the weight of wrath so that we could be drawn into the eternal embrace of the Father, Son, and Spirit. The cross does not end the conversation—it transforms it. In the silence, the language of mercy speaks with earth-shaking clarity. Jesus, the Word made flesh, speaks one final word—suffering love—and in doing so, reopens the dialogue between God and humanity. Even in silence, the cross remained a form of divine conversation—one in which justice and mercy met, and through which we are welcomed into the eternal fellowship of the Triune God.

Implications for Believers

What we've seen throughout this chapter is not merely theological insight—it is an invitation. The Trinity's eternal dialogue is not closed off to humanity. It has been opened, extended, and offered to us through Christ, by the Spirit, to the Father. As we glimpse the conversation of the Godhead through moments of affirmation, temptation, intercession, and suffering, we are invited to step into that rhythm ourselves.

1. Prayer as Participation

Prayer is not the start of conversation—it is our joining of one already in progress. The Spirit and the Son are already speaking; the Father is already listening. When we open our hearts in prayer, even

in silence or weakness, we step into a conversation older than time itself. Prayer is not a task we perform but a relationship we enter.

2. Endurance in Testing

In our own wildernesses, when the accuser speaks and God's voice feels distant, we follow Jesus' example. We answer the lies with truth. We hold fast to the Word. We let the Spirit guide and strengthen us, just as He did for Jesus. The divine conversation doesn't disappear in our struggle—it becomes our lifeline.

3. Embracing Unity

Jesus' final prayer before the cross was that we would be one as He and the Father are one. That kind of unity isn't found in uniformity or agreement on all things—it's forged in mutual love, shared truth, and divine intercession. If the Trinity is relational at its core, then the Church, as the image-bearing community of God, must live from and toward relational oneness.

4. Listening to the Spirit

The Spirit still speaks. He reminds, convicts, comforts, guides, and even prays when we cannot. To be people of the Spirit is to become fluent in divine dialogue. This means cultivating stillness, practicing attentiveness, and trusting that the same Spirit who hovered over

the waters still hovers over our lives, bringing form and beauty out of chaos.

Chapter 3: Learning to Converse with God *by Hazen*

People Pray in Desperate Times

There's a moment in the documentary *Grizzly Man*—raw, desperate, and painfully human—that captures something deep about the nature of prayer. Timothy Treadwell, a man who spent thirteen summers living among grizzly bears in Alaska's Katmai National Park, finds himself overwhelmed. A drought is threatening the animals he loves. He feels helpless. So he begins to pray.

But he doesn't pray in a way that fits any one tradition. He prays to everyone.

In a frantic, almost childlike plea, he calls out to “Jesus,” “Allah,” “Buddha,” “the Hindu floaty thing,” and any god or spirit that might be listening. He just wants rain—anything to help the bears survive.

And then, something eerie happens: it rains.

Treadwell's prayer, for all its confusion and improvisation, is followed almost immediately by a downpour. He's stunned. There's awe in his voice. Gratitude, too. But not transformation. He doesn't turn toward God. He doesn't begin a deeper conversation. He simply receives the rain and moves on.

He prayed. The rain came. But his life didn't change.

And that's the deeper tragedy.

Because the point isn't that prayer "works" like magic. The point is that *prayer is meant to form us*, not just fix things around us. It's not a lever we pull to get what we want—it's a life we step into to become who we were made to be.

What happened in that moment wasn't unique to Treadwell. It's something we all carry. Whether we identify as religious or not, there comes a time when we hit the end of ourselves—and instinctively, we cry out.

Everyone, eventually, prays.

The real question is: *What kind of person are you becoming through your prayers?*

Because the prayers that train us—the ones that build faith, shape obedience, and prepare us to finish well—don't begin in panic and end in silence. They begin in surrender. They continue in honesty.

And they grow over time into something fierce and resilient and beautiful.

Because prayer is more than a last resort—it's where we learn to fight, to stand, and to win.

Prayer is one of the most profound and life-giving aspects of faith, yet for many, it remains a mystery. Is it merely a ritual, a one-sided conversation, or a desperate plea in times of need? Or is it something more? This chapter explores prayer as a conversation—a living, breathing exchange that draws us deeper into communion with God.

My journey into this reality did not come easily. Like many, I (Hazen) grew up with a general understanding that prayer was important, but I lacked an expectation that God would speak in return. I was raised in a tradition that encouraged daily devotional time and acknowledged a personal relationship with God, but what that actually meant in practical terms was unclear to me. I understood prayer as a practice of speaking to God, but I never imagined it as a two-way conversation. That changed when I encountered God in a way that shattered my assumptions and transformed my understanding of prayer forever.

A Moment of Awakening

In my early college years, I found myself at a low point. A failed relationship, family tensions, and the growing realization that my external success could not satisfy my internal longing left me feeling lost. Outwardly, I had everything that should have brought fulfillment: a solid career path, good health, opportunities in leadership, friendships, and a promising future. Yet, inside, I was fractured. My choices, my emotions, and my sense of identity felt deeply unsettled.

Desperate for change, I turned to prayer in a way I never had before. I cried out to God, not with polished words, but with raw honesty. I needed Him to speak—not just for the sake of comfort but for direction, clarity, and transformation.

Then, something unexpected happened. I started to notice that the Scriptures I read spoke directly to my circumstances. A passage that seemed randomly chosen would address the exact question in my heart. Later in the day, that same Scripture might come up in a conversation, a sermon, or a song. At first, I dismissed it as coincidence, but the pattern continued. God was speaking, guiding, and responding in ways I could not ignore.

Biblical Foundations for Hearing God

As I examined the Bible, I saw that my experience was not unique. God had always been a speaking God.

- John 10:27: "My sheep hear my voice, and I know them, and they follow me."
- Isaiah 30:21: "Whether you turn to the right or to the left, your ears will hear a voice behind you, saying, 'This is the way; walk in it.'"
- Jeremiah 33:3: "Call to me and I will answer you and tell you great and unsearchable things you do not know."

From the beginning, God has communicated with His people—whether through His Word, His Spirit, visions, dreams, or the still, small voice in our hearts. The patriarchs, prophets, apostles, and early church leaders all experienced divine dialogue.

Jesus modeled this perfectly. He lived in constant conversation with the Father, stating in John 5:19, "The Son can do nothing by himself; he can do only what he sees his Father doing" (NIV). His entire ministry was guided by this ongoing communication.

A Shift in Perspective

Recognizing that God was speaking changed everything for me. I no longer saw prayer as a one-way monologue but as an invitation into divine conversation. The Holy Spirit, whom Jesus promised in John 16:13, was guiding me into all truth, revealing insights, directing my steps, and confirming His will through various means.

This realization transformed my prayer life. Instead of seeing prayer as merely presenting requests, I began to listen. Instead of striving to figure things out on my own, I sought God's wisdom. My heart became attuned to His presence, not only in structured prayer times but throughout my day.

Proverbs 3:5-6 encourages us, "Trust in the Lord with all your heart and lean not on your own understanding; in all your ways submit to him, and he will make your paths straight." The more I acknowledged God in my daily life, the more I saw His hand leading me.

Everyone Prays

If you were to ask the average person, "Have you ever prayed?" chances are they'd say yes. Even people who don't consider themselves particularly religious often admit to praying at some point—especially in moments of crisis or uncertainty. Whether it

was a desperate plea for help, a silent hope for healing, or a quick “God, please” during an emergency, almost everyone has reached out to something—or Someone—beyond themselves. *Even Timothy Treadwell, in the middle of the Alaskan wilderness, instinctively cried out when things got desperate.* Prayer is a human reflex before it’s a spiritual discipline.

There’s something deep in us that wants to believe Someone is listening.

But if you follow up with, “Have you ever seen a clear, undeniable answer to prayer?” the number of people who say yes gets a lot smaller.

And if you ask “Do you talk with God regularly? Do you hear His voice?”, most people pause. They’re not sure how to answer. For many, prayer feels like a one-way street—a message sent out into the sky, with no idea if it’s ever received. Others might say, “I don’t know if I hear God. I’m not even sure what that would sound like.”

This gap between *saying prayers* and actually *hearing God* is one of the reasons this book exists.

The truth is, Scripture paints a much more interactive picture of what our relationship with God can be like. In Exodus 33:11, we read:

“The Lord would speak to Moses face to face, as one speaks to a friend.”

Moses didn’t just believe in God—he spoke with Him. He had real conversations with Him. And what’s even more incredible is that, as New Testament believers, we’re invited into something even more intimate.

Hebrews 8:6 says:

“The ministry Jesus has received is as superior to theirs as the covenant of which he is mediator is superior to the old one, since the new covenant is established on better promises.”

In other words, the relationship Moses had with God—one that many of us see as almost impossible—is just the starting point under the new covenant. Through Jesus, we’re not only saved; we’re welcomed into a deeper kind of relationship—one where communication with God isn’t rare or reserved for spiritual elites but is available to all His children.

Romans 8:15–16 explains it this way:

“The Spirit you received does not make you slaves, so that you live in fear again; rather, the Spirit you received brought about your adoption to sonship. And

by him we cry, ‘Abba, Father.’ The Spirit himself testifies with our spirit that we are God’s children.”

If you’ve put your faith in Jesus, you’ve received His Spirit. That means you’ve been adopted into God’s family. And because of that, you now have the ability to talk with your Father—and to hear from Him too.

Prayer is more than just sending requests to God. It’s meant to be a conversation—a living, growing relationship. You were created not just to *pray* but to *relate*. To hear. To respond. To know God, not just believe in Him from a distance.

So yes—everyone prays. But not everyone knows they can experience prayer as a two-way conversation. That’s what this book is about. Helping you learn what it means to walk with God in real dialogue. Because that’s the relationship you were made for.

Honestly, most of humanity prays in some form in the sense that they make requests of their ‘god’ or ‘gods’. This practice is a pillar of every major world religion.

- **Islam**, the world’s second-largest religion, emphasizes structured prayer five times a day (Salah), yet expressly denies that humanity could call upon God as Father.

- **Hinduism** and **Buddhism** have deep traditions of meditative and devotional prayer.
- **Judaism** teaches a personal but reverent approach to prayer, addressing God as Sovereign.

However, not everyone who prays is "heard" in the biblical sense. Heard a biblical sense meaning: their prayer is received and responded to by God because of a restored relationship. When Christians pray to God, we call upon Him as "Father." When the world calls upon God, though He sometimes responds in His mercy, they do not cry out with the confidence that comes through the new birth.

This understanding—that Christians approach God as Father through Jesus Christ—is foundational and distinct from every other faith. In fact, the first words Jesus taught His disciples to pray were:

- **Matthew 6:9** - "Our Father in heaven, hallowed be your name."

This phrase holds a profound truth: God is both "Abba"—our intimate Father—and "in heaven"—the sovereign, uncreated Creator of the universe.

The word "Abba" is one of the most intimate and revealing terms used in Scripture to describe our relationship with God. In ancient

Jewish culture, "Abba" was an affectionate term used exclusively by children for their fathers: signifying trust, closeness, and dependence. It was not a distant, formal address but a deeply personal one—akin to "Daddy" or "Papa" in English. When Jesus taught His disciples to pray, He introduced this radical idea that they could call upon God in the same intimate way that He did. The fact that Jesus likely spoke these words in Aramaic means He may have originally used "Abba". Paul reinforces this truth that we can call on God as Daddy in Romans 8:15-16, stating, "The Spirit you received does not make you slaves, so that you live in fear again; rather, the Spirit you received brought about your adoption to sonship. And by him we cry, 'Abba, Father.' The Spirit himself testifies with our spirit that we are God's children." By using both "Abba" and "Father" Paul highlights the profound privilege believers have in addressing God with both deep intimacy and profound reverence.

However, the significance of "Abba" does not stop at intimacy. Jesus paired "Abba" with the phrase "in heaven" to emphasize that while God is deeply personal and relational, He is also the sovereign, omnipotent Creator who reigns over all. He is both near and transcendent, both loving and all-powerful. This balance is crucial to understanding Christian prayer—we approach God with confidence as beloved children while also revering Him as the Almighty King.

Paul reinforces this truth in Galatians 4:6-7, stating, "Because you are his sons, God sent the Spirit of his Son into our hearts, the Spirit who calls out, 'Abba, Father.' So you are no longer a slave, but God's child; and since you are his child, God has made you also an heir." This means that through Christ, we have not only been saved but also adopted into the very family of God, securing our right to call upon Him as "Abba." This verse highlights the depth of our new identity in Christ—not as distant subjects, but as beloved children with an inheritance in God's eternal kingdom.

This is what makes Christian prayer distinct from every other religious practice. While many world religions emphasize structured prayers, rituals, or reverent but distant interactions with the divine, Christianity uniquely invites believers into a family relationship with God. Our prayers are not mere petitions to an unknown deity but conversations with our loving Father, who both hears and responds.

Our Prayers Before God's Throne

Without a love relationship with God, our prayers are empty words. Our ability to call upon God as Father is the very foundation of why we can approach Him with confidence in prayer. This truth is reinforced throughout Scripture, showing the unique privilege believers have in addressing God as 'Abba, Father.'

- **1 Corinthians 13:1** - "If I speak in the tongues of men or of angels, but do not have love, I am only a resounding gong or a clanging cymbal."

However, when we pray in the Spirit, in Jesus' name, our prayers rise before God like incense. The book of Revelation provides a powerful image of this divine exchange, where the prayers of God's people ascend like fragrant offerings before His throne. This imagery reminds us that prayer is not only communication with God but also an act of worship that is received in heaven:

- **Revelation 5:8** - "Each one had a harp and they were holding golden bowls full of incense, which are the prayers of God's people."
- **Revelation 8:3-4** - "Another angel, who had a golden censer, came and stood at the altar. He was given much incense to offer, with the prayers of all God's people, on the golden altar in front of the throne. The smoke of the incense, together with the prayers of God's people, went up before God from the angel's hand."

Our prayers, when offered in faith and love, are not empty rituals. They ascend to the very presence of God, joining in the worship of heaven.

Andrew Murray on Prayer

One of the greatest voices on prayer in Christian history was Andrew Murray (1828–1917), a South African pastor, missionary, and writer. Murray was a leading advocate for deeper spiritual life and intimacy with God. He wrote extensively on prayer, humility, and the abiding life in Christ. His teachings continue to inspire generations to seek a closer relationship with God through devoted prayer.

Early in our marriage, my wife and I read Murray's book on prayer together. It became part of our daily devotional practice, especially during our drives to and from the church where we worked. Those moments of reading and discussing Murray's words laid a strong foundation in our lives, shaping our understanding of what prayer truly is—and what it is not. His insights helped us see prayer not as a duty or obligation but as an invitation into deeper fellowship with God: a constant and ongoing dialogue rather than a mere religious practice.

He once wrote:

"Prayer is not monologue, but dialogue. God's voice in response to mine is its most essential part."

This statement encapsulates the essence of prayer as a conversation, not merely a recitation of needs. Murray believed that time spent in prayer was not wasted but was the very foundation of fruitful spiritual life.

"Time spent in prayer will yield more than that given to work. Prayer alone gives work its worth and its success. Prayer opens the way for God Himself to do His work in us and through us."

This concept reflects the same truth that Jesus illustrated in John 15:4-5, where He said:

"Remain in me, as I also remain in you. No branch can bear fruit by itself; it must remain in the vine. Neither can you bear fruit unless you remain in me. I am the vine; you are the branches. If you remain in me and I in you, you will bear much fruit; apart from me you can do nothing."

Jesus' metaphor of the vine and branches teaches that spiritual fruitfulness is entirely dependent on an abiding relationship with Him. This abiding is nurtured through continual communion—prayer, listening to His voice, and meditating on His word. Just as a branch cannot sustain itself apart from the vine, our spiritual lives wither without the lifeline of conversation with God.

Therefore, conversation with God is not just an aspect of faith; it is foundational to a fruitful life of abiding in Him, ensuring that His life flows through us, bringing growth, strength, and purpose.

Invitation to a Life of Conversation with God

Whether you are new to prayer or have been walking with God for years, there is always more to discover in the realm of divine conversation. Prayer is not a skill to master. It's a relationship to nurture—a constant dialogue that deepens over time. Just as in any meaningful relationship, the more we engage, listen, and respond, the more we grow in intimacy and understanding.

There will be seasons when prayer flows effortlessly, and other times when it feels like a struggle. But through it all, the invitation remains the same: to draw near, to listen, and to speak. God is not a distant figure waiting to be impressed by perfect words; He is a loving Father who desires our presence more than our performance. This book is a journey into making that conversation a reality—a journey into a life where prayer is not an obligation but a living, breathing exchange of love, trust, and transformation.

My hope is that as you read, you will begin to recognize the many ways God is already speaking to you. That you will see prayer not as an obligation but as the most natural and transformative conversation you could ever have.

So let's begin the journey together—into a life of prayer that is rich, dynamic, and undeniably real.

A Closing Prayer

Father,

Thank You for inviting me into conversation.

Not as a servant kept at a distance,
but as a child, welcomed with love.

Help me to grow in this relationship—not just learning how to pray,
but learning how to be with You.

Teach me to listen.

Give me courage to speak honestly.

And let this journey draw me closer to Your heart.

Amen.

Reflection Prompt

Take a moment and think about your current experience of prayer.

- How would you describe it: consistent, distant, confusing, rich?
- Have you ever sensed God speaking to you—through Scripture, someone else, or in your heart?

- What would it look like to treat prayer less like a task and more like a conversation?

Application: Write a few honest thoughts in a journal, or speak them aloud to God as a starting point.

Chapter 4: Conversations About God

Can Be Prayer *by Hazen*

Introduction: A Different Kind of Prayer

When we think of prayer, we often picture quiet moments alone—heads bowed, eyes closed, words whispered or unspoken, reaching toward heaven (and we will talk about this kind of prayer shortly). But first, what if prayer is not just something we do in solitude? What if prayer can also be found in the words we share with others?

Jesus made a powerful promise:

“For where two or three gather in my name, there am I with them” (Matthew 18:20, NIV).

This verse reminds us that prayer is not just an individual experience; it is also something that happens in community. When we gather with others and speak about God—when we discuss who He is, share what He has done, and reflect on His truth—our conversations can become acts of worship.

God is not only present in our private devotions but also in the spaces where believers come together to talk about Him. In fact, Scripture tells us that God listens when we speak of Him with reverence:

“Then those who feared the Lord talked with each other, and the Lord listened and heard. A scroll of remembrance was written in his presence concerning those who feared the Lord and honored his name”
(Malachi 3:16, NIV).

This passage gives us a stunning truth: our conversations about God are not just ordinary discussions—they are sacred moments, recorded in heaven. When we speak about God with sincerity and honor, He listens.

The Power of Spiritual Conversations

Throughout Scripture, we see how conversations about God are more than just words. They become encounters.

One of the most powerful examples of this is found in Luke 24:13-35, the story of the disciples on the road to Emmaus. After Jesus’ crucifixion, two disciples were walking together, trying to make sense of what had happened. As they discussed Jesus’ death and the rumors of His resurrection, they were joined by a stranger.

“As they talked and discussed these things with each other, Jesus himself came up and walked along with them; but they were kept from recognizing him” (Luke 24:15-16, NIV).

Jesus entered their conversation, even when they didn’t realize He was there. As they continued talking, He explained the Scriptures to them, revealing God’s plan in a way they had never understood before. Later, when He broke bread with them, their eyes were opened, and they recognized Him.

“They asked each other, ‘Were not our hearts burning within us while he talked with us on the road and opened the Scriptures to us?’” (Luke 24:32, NIV).

This passage is a profound reminder that when we discuss spiritual things, Jesus often joins us. The phrase “Were not our hearts burning within us while he talked with us on the road and opened the Scriptures to us?” suggests an unmistakable internal confirmation of divine truth. This was not just an intellectual awakening but a deep, spiritual stirring—a recognition that they had encountered the living Word. Their hearts burned because their spirits were ignited with the revelation of Christ. Similarly, when we speak of God in faith-filled conversations, there are moments when we feel that same stirring, that unmistakable sense that God is illuminating His truth, drawing us deeper into His presence. Our

conversations about God are not just about exchanging thoughts; they are opportunities for divine revelation, moments when eternity touches time and the voice of Christ echoes through our dialogue.

Holy Moments in Community

I have experienced this firsthand as a part of a committed men's small group where we built deep relationships, explored the bible, confessed our sins, and prayed for one another. Week after week, we gather to share our struggles and victories and to grow in our faith. Some discussions feel like wrestling matches with truth, while others become moments of profound clarity where we sense God speaking through one another.

One evening, I found myself sharing a deep place of pain that I had never voiced before. For years, I had not felt safe enough to expose such wounds, but, in that moment, something within me broke open. A deep well of emotion surfaced, and I could no longer hold it back. The men around me did not rush to fix or offer quick words of encouragement. Instead, they simply sat with me. One placed a reassuring hand on my shoulder, another quietly wept alongside me. A guttural wail escaped from my depths, an outpouring of pain that had been locked away.

In that sacred moment, I experienced the love of God in a way I never had before, not through personal prayer in solitude, but

through the presence of my brothers in Christ. The safety of that fellowship allowed me to bear my brokenness before God. And in doing so, He met me there amongst my brothers. They (the trinity & my brothers) met me in my grief, in my vulnerability, in my rawest pain. But the encounter was not the result of structured prayer—it was birthed in a conversation, a holy moment stewarded by men who knew how to hold space for one another before God.

“Blessed are those who mourn, for they will be comforted” (Philippians 4:19, NIV).

As I wept, and my brothers in Christ surrounded me with silent support, their presence became a living reminder of God’s nearness to the brokenhearted. Their prayers were not only in the words they might have spoken but in their presence, in the unwavering stillness with which they carried the weight of the moment with me.

In that moment I experienced something was healed in me, and I can truthfully say I have never been the same. It was not just something I understood theologically; it was something I could feel, a new peace and quiet trust, birthed from the empathy, the unspoken intercession, and the sacred stillness of brothers who knew how to join me in my grief. This was prayer in its rawest form—not shaped by eloquent words, but by the shared experience of carrying one another’s burdens before God. In that space, He

ministered, not just to me but to all of us, allowing His presence to move through the authenticity and love that filled the room.

I have experienced many holy moments in personal prayer and worship, but I have also found that sacred encounters often take place in conversation—with others, and with hearts wide open. These moments arise when we choose to speak about God with depth and sincerity and when we're willing to share vulnerably from our own lives. As Paul wrote to the Corinthians: *"Oh, dear Corinthian friends! We have spoken honestly with you, and our hearts are open to you. There is no lack of love on our part, but you have withheld your love from us. I am asking you to respond as if you were my own children. Open your hearts to us!"* (2 Corinthians 6:11–13, NLT). In the same way, spiritual conversations refine us, challenge us, and draw us closer to God. When we open our hearts with authenticity, we create space for true transformation. We are invited to be fully seen and known—even in our hurting, ugly, or broken places. Honest dialogue tears down the walls of isolation and allows the Holy Spirit to move through our relationships. These sacred exchanges not only deepen our faith but also strengthen our bonds, as we bear one another's burdens, offer encouragement, and experience the tangible love of God through each other's presence.

As Christian psychologist and spiritual director David G. Benner writes in *Surrender to Love*, "The single most important thing I have learned in over thirty years of study of how love produces healing is

that love is transformational only when it is received in vulnerability.” True transformation begins when we allow both God and others to love us as we genuinely are.

Recognizing When a Conversation Becomes Prayer

Not every conversation about God carries the same weight. Some are casual, surface-level discussions. Others—often unexpectedly—become sacred encounters: moments where God speaks, convicts, or moves powerfully.

Consider the story of Philip and the Ethiopian eunuch in Acts 8:26-39. Philip was led by the Spirit to approach a man reading Isaiah. Their conversation began as an exchange of questions and answers about Scripture, but it quickly became an encounter with God.

“Then Philip began with that very passage of Scripture and told him the good news about Jesus. As they traveled along the road, they came to some water and the eunuch said, ‘Look, here is water. What can stand in the way of my being baptized?’” (Acts 8:35-36, NIV).

The conversation led to transformation. This is what happens when the Holy Spirit enters our discussions—we are not just talking; we are encountering God.

How to Cultivate Prayerful Conversations

If we want our conversations about God to carry spiritual power, we must be intentional. Meaningful spiritual discussions don't happen by accident; they require a heart that is open, ears that are attentive, and a spirit that is sensitive to the movement of God. When we engage in conversations about God with purpose, we create space for His presence to transform those moments into something sacred.

Just as Jesus was intentional in His conversations—whether teaching His disciples, challenging religious leaders, or speaking life into those who felt unseen—we too must approach spiritual discussions with wisdom and care. Through these conversations, we invite the Holy Spirit to work, shaping our hearts and the hearts of those around us.

Here are a few ways to cultivate prayerful discussions:

1. **Gather in His Name** – When we meet with others, we should be intentional about centering our conversations on Christ. This means more than simply mentioning His name

in passing—it means inviting His presence into the discussion, aligning our thoughts and words with His truth, and allowing His Spirit to guide our dialogue.

Jesus assured us that when we gather in His name, He is there with us. When we intentionally focus on Him, our conversations can become opportunities for revelation, encouragement, and deep spiritual connection. Whether we are discussing theology, sharing testimonies, or encouraging one another in faith, making Christ the foundation of our conversations transforms them from ordinary discussions into moments of prayer and worship.

We see this modeled in the early church. In Acts 2:42-47, the believers devoted themselves to teaching, fellowship, and breaking bread together in Christ's name. Their conversations weren't merely social exchanges; they were deeply spiritual, filled with the presence of God.

It says, "They worshiped together at the Temple each day, met in homes for the Lord's Supper, and shared their meals with great joy and generosity—all the while praising God and enjoying the goodwill of all the people. And each day the Lord added to their fellowship those who were being saved" (NLT).

This passage reveals how their Christ-centered conversations created an atmosphere where God moved powerfully among them.

Another example is found in Matthew 16:13-20, when Jesus asked His disciples, *"Who do people say the Son of Man is?"* This conversation was not just a theological discussion; it was an invitation to revelation. When Peter declared, *"You are the Messiah, the Son of the living God,"* Jesus affirmed that this truth was revealed not by flesh and blood but by the Father in heaven. This shows us that when we gather in Christ's name and seek truth together, the Holy Spirit grants revelation that deepens our faith.

Likewise, when Paul and Silas were imprisoned in Acts 16:25-26, they prayed and sang hymns to God. Though they were bound in chains, their conversations in worship and prayer ushered in divine intervention—an earthquake shook the prison, and their chains were loosed. This reminds us that when we intentionally bring God into our conversations, whether in joy or suffering, His presence transforms those moments in ways we could never expect. This means more than simply mentioning His name in passing—it means inviting His presence into the discussion, aligning our thoughts and words with His truth, and allowing His Spirit to guide our dialogue. Jesus assured us

that when we gather in His name, He is there with us. When we intentionally focus on Him, our conversations can become opportunities for revelation, encouragement, and deep spiritual connection. Whether we are discussing theology, sharing testimonies, or encouraging one another in faith, making Christ the foundation of our conversations transforms them from ordinary discussions into moments of prayer and worship.

2. **Listen with Spiritual Ears** – Instead of just waiting for our turn to speak, we should listen for the ways God is moving in the conversation. True listening goes beyond simply hearing words; it involves discerning the voice of God through what is being spoken. Jesus often emphasized the importance of listening with spiritual sensitivity, as He did in Matthew 13:9, saying, *'Anyone with ears to hear should listen and understand!'*

One example of this in Scripture is found in 1 Samuel 3:1-10, where young Samuel hears God calling his name but does not recognize it at first. It is only when Eli instructs him to say, *'Speak, Lord, for your servant is listening,'* that Samuel truly attunes himself to hear God's voice. Likewise, when we engage in spiritual conversations, we must approach them with an open heart, listening not just for human words but for the movement of the Holy Spirit within them.

Another powerful illustration is found in Acts 10, when Peter receives a vision from God while praying. At first, he does not fully understand what the vision means, but as he listens to the Spirit and engages in conversation with Cornelius' household, the revelation unfolds. This shows us that spiritual discernment often happens in stages, and that God may use a conversation to reveal deeper truths over time.

When we listen with spiritual ears, we allow God to speak through others, bringing encouragement, wisdom, and sometimes even correction. We should approach every conversation prayerfully, asking, *'Lord, what are You saying in this moment?'* and being willing to adjust our own thoughts and responses as the Spirit leads.

3. **Encourage and Build Up** – Our words should give grace to those who hear. Encouragement is a vital part of fostering spiritual conversations that bring life and strength to those around us. When we choose to use our words to uplift, we are partnering with God in His work of transformation and healing. The Bible repeatedly emphasizes the power of speech, reminding us that our words can either build up or tear down.

In Proverbs 18:21, we read, *'The tongue can bring death or life; those who love to talk will reap the consequences.'* This highlights the reality that our words hold incredible weight—what we say has the potential to bring spiritual vitality or discouragement. When we intentionally speak words that edify, we reflect the heart of God and create space for His Spirit to move.

A powerful example of encouragement in Scripture is seen in Barnabas, whose name literally means *'Son of Encouragement.'* In Acts 9:26-27, when Saul (later Paul) attempted to join the disciples after his dramatic conversion, many were afraid of him because of his past as a persecutor of Christians. But Barnabas came alongside him, advocating for him, affirming his testimony, and helping him integrate into the early church. Without Barnabas' encouragement, Paul might not have been received by the church as quickly.

Similarly, in 1 Thessalonians 5:11, Paul writes, *'So encourage each other and build each other up, just as you are already doing.'* This verse reminds us that encouragement should be a regular practice in our interactions, not just an occasional gesture.

When we speak words of grace, truth, and encouragement, we create a spiritual atmosphere where people can grow in

faith, find renewed strength, and step into their God-given calling. A simple word of affirmation, a reminder of God's faithfulness, or a testimony of His goodness can shift someone's perspective and inspire them to trust Him more fully.

“Do not let any unwholesome talk come out of your mouths, but only what is helpful for building others up according to their needs, that it may benefit those who listen” (Ephesians 4:29, NIV).

4. Ask Good Questions – Jesus often used questions to invite people into deeper spiritual reflection. Rather than simply giving direct answers, He engaged people in a way that required them to search their hearts and think critically about their beliefs.

Similarly, in Luke 10:25-37, when a lawyer asked Jesus what he must do to inherit eternal life, Jesus responded with a question: *“What is written in the Law? How do you read it?”* Instead of providing an immediate answer, Jesus encouraged him to reflect on the truth already present in Scripture. This method allowed the lawyer to arrive at an answer himself and led to the parable of the Good Samaritan, which deepened the conversation even further.

Asking good questions can open the door for meaningful spiritual discussions, helping others process their faith journey more deeply. Whether in a discipleship setting, a small group discussion, or an evangelistic conversation, thoughtful questions can create space for revelation and transformation.

5. **Recognize When a Conversation Becomes Worship –**

Sometimes, a discussion naturally turns into a time of gratitude, confession, or even spontaneous prayer. When our words align with God’s truth, and our hearts become engaged with His presence, our conversations can shift from ordinary dialogue into sacred moments of worship. This happens when we begin to acknowledge God’s goodness, express awe at His works, or feel compelled to respond to His presence with reverence.

A clear example of this is found in **Nehemiah 8:5-6**, when Ezra reads the Book of the Law to the people. As they listen, the entire assembly is moved to worship:

“Ezra stood on the platform in full view of all the people. When they saw him open the book, they all rose to their feet. Then Ezra praised the Lord, the great God, and all the people chanted, ‘Amen! Amen!’ as they lifted their

hands. Then they bowed down and worshiped the Lord with their faces to the ground” (Nehemiah 8:5-6, NLT).

What began as a reading of Scripture turned into a moment of deep reverence and worship. Similarly, in Luke 1:39-45, when Mary visits Elizabeth, their conversation is so filled with the Spirit that Elizabeth is overcome with joy and proclaims a blessing over Mary. Their words shift from personal discussion to a spontaneous declaration of God's faithfulness:

"A few days later Mary hurried to the hill country of Judea, to the town where Zechariah lived. She entered the house and greeted Elizabeth. At the sound of Mary's greeting, Elizabeth's child leaped within her, and Elizabeth was filled with the Holy Spirit. Elizabeth gave a glad cry and exclaimed to Mary, 'God has blessed you above all women, and your child is blessed. Why am I so honored, that the mother of my Lord should visit me? When I heard your greeting, the baby in my womb jumped for joy. You are blessed because you believed that the Lord would do what he said.'" (Luke 1:39-45, NLT)

This passage shows how the presence of God can turn a simple greeting into a prophetic moment of worship. Elizabeth's words were not just human

encouragement; they were inspired by the Holy Spirit, affirming Mary's faith and proclaiming the significance of Jesus even before His birth. This kind of spiritually charged conversation reminds us that when we invite God into our interactions, He often reveals His truth and presence in ways we could never anticipate.

These moments remind us that worship is not confined to a church service or a song—it can arise in everyday conversations when hearts are stirred toward God. Recognizing when a conversation has become worship requires sensitivity to the Holy Spirit and a willingness to respond with awe, praise, or even silence in reverence.

Chapter 5: Private Conversations

With God *by Hannah*

Before we explore the private conversations of biblical heroes, I want to share a moment that shaped my own journey.

In college, I spent a semester on a wilderness program in New Zealand. As part of the journey, we were each sent on a three-day solo—a time of total isolation in the Hobbiton Shire. I was dropped off under a tree on a hillside with nothing but a bible, sleeping bag, a tarp, a water bottle, and no clear sense of when I would be picked up. It was just me, the wind, the silence, a few rugged cows, and the sound of distant birds.

At first, I was restless. My mind raced, my body fidgeted. But as the hours stretched into days, something unexpected happened: the silence began to settle inside me. I became profoundly aware of God's presence—not in a loud, spectacular way, but in the stillness of the trees, the quiet of the stars, the softness of breath. I felt held, seen, and accompanied. That moment marked me for life. I walked away with a deep appreciation—and love—for silence and solitude. It's become part of how I encounter God.

Anyone who knows my husband Hazen is already smiling. Because if you know him, you know he's the type who loves to "talk things through"—right then, right there, with all the words. So yes, this has definitely been a tension in our marriage. I crave space and quiet to process. He wants eye contact and dialogue. And over the years, we've stretched each other. We've grown. I've learned the value of verbal processing, and he's learned the beauty of patient silence. God has used even that difference to shape us. You likely fall somewhere on the spectrum between the two of us, but whether it is in the quiet and beauty of nature or fervent expressive dialogue, God longs to talk to you.

In recent years, I've had the joy of leading silent retreats. As a spiritual director, I walk with people as they open their hearts to God—not through discussion or debate, but through slow, sacred stillness. During those retreats, their only conversation happens with me. And even then, it's more about listening than talking. It's amazing to see how silence—paired with thoughtful, honest conversation—becomes a tool of transformation.

There is something about solitude that opens us to God's presence. Something about silence that draws our truest questions to the surface. And when we speak, finally, we speak from a deeper place.

This chapter is about that kind of speech.

Private conversations with God have shaped the heroes of faith. Abraham's wandering beneath the stars. Moses' awe before the burning bush. David's raw songs on the backside of shepherd's hills. Mary's weeping and worship at Jesus' feet. Even Jesus Himself, who often withdrew to lonely places in the dark of night to pray. These weren't staged or performative. They were hidden, holy, deeply personal moments that formed real relationship.

So as we enter into this chapter, I want you to picture your own tree in the wilderness—your own secret place, however and wherever you find it. Because the same God who met them there is waiting to meet you too.

Abraham: A Friendship Built on Trust and Conversation

It was a quiet night, the kind where the desert air cools and the stars emerge one by one in a velvet-black sky. Abraham stood alone, weary and questioning. The promise God had made still hadn't come to pass—no child, no heir, just silence and waiting. But then God spoke.

"Come outside," He seemed to say. *"Look up."*

So Abraham stepped out beneath the night sky, lifting his eyes toward the heavens. The stars—uncountable, dazzling,

infinite—spread out before him. And in that holy hush, God said, *“Look up at the sky and count the stars—if indeed you can count them... So shall your offspring be.”* (Genesis 15:5, NIV)

It wasn't just a metaphor or a poetic gesture. It was a conversation—a personal, relational moment where God met Abraham not with rebuke but with vision. A childless man looking at a sky full of descendants. A friend looking into the heart of a promise. In that moment, faith sparked again, and Abraham believed.

This is the beauty of Abraham's relationship with God. It was built not just on commands or rituals, but on trust and deep, ongoing dialogue. Scripture tells us, *“Abraham believed God, and God counted him as righteous because of his faith”* And then James adds: *“He was even called the friend of God”* (James 2:23, NLT). Isaiah affirms it as well: *“Abraham, my friend”* (Isaiah 41:8, ESV).

Their friendship began with a call that had no map: *“Go from your country, your people and your father's household to the land I will show you”* (Genesis 12:1, NIV).

No plan. No destination. Just a promise. And Abraham said yes.

But friendship with God doesn't mean certainty—it means conversation. In Genesis 15, Abraham brought his doubts: *“Sovereign Lord, what can you give me since I remain childless?”*

(Genesis 15:2, NIV).

And God responded with stars.

Later, God changed his name from Abram to Abraham—“*father of many*.” This wasn’t just a new label; it was a redefinition of identity, one forged through the ongoing relationship between Creator and created. Even when Abraham laughed at the idea of having a son in old age (Genesis 17:17), God didn’t walk away. He stayed close.

That’s what it means to be a friend of God. Not a perfect life, but a heart that keeps showing up. Not the absence of questions, but the willingness to ask them. Abraham’s story reminds us that friendship with God is formed in conversation—in the asking, the listening, the walking, and even the wondering beneath a sky full of stars.

And here’s the wonder: *we* are a part of that same conversation. The promise God made to Abraham was not only fulfilled in Isaac, but through Christ, it has been fulfilled in us. Paul writes, “*Those who have faith are children of Abraham*” (Galatians 3:7, NIV). Through the Gospel, you and I—who believe by faith—have Abraham as our spiritual father. We are counted among those stars, part of the great family of faith that stretches across centuries and nations. The promise continues and so does the friendship. You are part of God’s eternal story—a descendant of promise, a friend of God, a light among the stars.

Moses: The Conversation That Refused to End

It began with fire.

Not the kind that destroys, but the kind that draws you closer.

Alone in the wilderness, tending sheep in the stillness of Mount Horeb, Moses noticed a bush ablaze—burning, yet not consumed. He turned aside to see, and in that moment, everything changed.

From the center of the flame, God called his name: “*Moses, Moses.*” And Moses replied, “*Here I am*” (Exodus 3:4).

This was no passing encounter. This was an invitation—into dialogue, into purpose, into relationship. God didn’t simply give Moses a task; He revealed His heart. He spoke of His people’s suffering, of His desire to deliver them, and of His plan to send Moses. There, barefoot before a burning bush, Moses stepped into the sacred rhythm of conversation with the living God.

And the conversation never stopped.

Through every confrontation in Egypt, through every cry in the wilderness, Moses kept talking to God—and God kept responding. Scripture says, “*The Lord would speak to Moses face to face, as one speaks to a friend*” (Exodus 33:11).

This became the defining trait of Moses' leadership—not charisma, not strategy, not strength—but closeness. When Israel rebelled, Moses didn't abandon them—he interceded. When he didn't understand God's ways, he asked. When he was uncertain about his ability to lead, he confessed it openly: *"If your Presence does not go with us, do not send us up from here"* (Exodus 33:15).

He wasn't looking for divine assistance—he was longing for God Himself. And God responded—not with vague encouragement but with revelation. God revealed His name: *"I AM WHO I AM."* He revealed His character: *"compassionate and gracious, slow to anger, abounding in love and faithfulness"* (Exodus 34:6).

Moses began to meet with God regularly—first in the Tent of Meeting, where the pillar of cloud would descend and God would speak with him. Eventually, he would meet with God before the ark of the covenant, in the inner sanctuary of the tabernacle, where the glory of the Lord would dwell above the mercy seat. These weren't quiet devotionals. They were bold, raw, ongoing conversations with a holy God who listened.

Moses' life shows us that spiritual maturity isn't about having all the answers—it's about staying in the dialogue. Asking. Listening. Returning again and again to the place of presence.

David: A Life of Worship, Complaint, and Trust

Long before the palace, before the crown, before the battlefield victories and political intrigue—there was a boy with a lyre and a flock of sheep.

Under the wide skies of Bethlehem, David kept watch. The rhythm of his life was quiet and hidden, marked not by applause but by faithful presence. And in that solitude, he began to sing. His fingers strummed melodies on the lyre as his heart reached toward heaven. He sang of God’s nearness, God’s beauty, God’s strength. These early songs weren’t written for crowds—they were prayers sung beneath stars, offered to an audience of One.

It was in the pasture, not the palace, that David learned to worship. There he discovered God not as a distant deity, but as a Shepherd, a Shield, a Friend. And in that field, the foundation was laid for what would become a life centered on *one thing*:

“One thing I have desired of the Lord, that will I seek: that I may dwell in the house of the Lord all the days of my life, to behold the beauty of the Lord, and to inquire in His temple”
(Psalm 27:4, NKJV).

That singular pursuit—to behold God, to dwell with Him—shaped David’s life. And when the path turned dark—through betrayal, failure, and loss—that longing kept him tethered.

While Moses and Abraham had audible exchanges with God, David teaches us how to pray when God feels silent. Through the Psalms, we see his soul laid bare—songs of joy, cries of desperation, confessions of sin, and declarations of trust. He brought everything into the conversation—fear, failure, anger, wonder, repentance, longing. He dared to believe that God wanted all of it, not just the polished parts.

David referred to God not just as the Almighty, but as his hiding place, his refuge, his home.

“He who dwells in the secret place of the Most High shall abide under the shadow of the Almighty” (Psalm 91:1, NKJV).

“My heart has heard you say, ‘Come and talk with me.’ And my heart responds, ‘Lord, I am coming’” (Psalm 27:8, NLT).

This was not the language of religion—it was the language of relationship. David carved out sacred space to pour out his heart without a filter. The Psalms are proof of a long-running, private dialogue where God was not just a king’s God—but David’s God.

And though David failed—grievously at times—God did not define him by his worst moments. Instead, Scripture tells us, *“After David*

had served the purpose of God in his own generation, he fell asleep...” (Acts 13:36, ESV). In God’s eyes, he was still “*a man after My own heart, who will do all My will*” (Acts 13:22, NKJV).

That’s mercy. That’s grace. That’s the kind of friendship God offers—where repentance reopens the conversation, and devotion is remembered more than failure.

David’s story reminds us that God doesn’t just want our victories—He wants our voices. Even when we’re in the wilderness. Even when we’re afraid. Even when we’re wrong. He welcomes the honest heart. And like David, we are invited into a life of worship, complaint, and trust—a life marked by *one thing*, shaped by mercy, and remembered as one who fulfilled the will of God in our generation.

Mary of Bethany: The Fragrance of Friendship

We first see her at His feet.

While others busied themselves with serving and managing the moment, Mary of Bethany chose stillness. She sat at the feet of Jesus, wide-eyed and wonder-filled, listening to every word as if each one was a treasure. Her sister Martha was frustrated, but Jesus was not. He said, “*Mary has chosen what is better, and it will not be taken away from her*” (Luke 10:42).

This wasn't a moment of laziness—it was the beginning of a deep, relational devotion. Mary wasn't just near Jesus. *She knew Him.*

Scripture tells us that Jesus loved Mary, her sister Martha, and her brother Lazarus (John 11:5). Their home in Bethany was one of the few places on earth where Jesus was fully received, fully welcomed. So when Lazarus died, the ache was heavy—not only for Mary, but for Jesus Himself.

Mary, heartbroken, came to Him weeping. She fell at His feet again—this time not in peace, but in grief. And Jesus met her there. He didn't correct her tears. He joined them: *“Jesus wept”* (John 11:35).

The shortest verse in the Bible, and perhaps the most profound. The Son of God—moved by the sorrow of His friend—entered into her pain before raising her brother from the grave.

Mary was not only emotionally present; she was spiritually attuned in a way even the Twelve seemed to miss. In the final days before the cross, while others still expected crowns and thrones, Mary perceived the costly road Jesus was walking. And so, in a quiet but extravagant act of devotion, she anointed Him.

She broke open a jar of pure nard, a precious and costly perfume—likely her dowry, meant for the day of her wedding. She poured it out at Jesus' feet, wiping them with her hair. It was

more than an honor. It was friendship. It was love. It was prophetic preparation.

The disciples scoffed. The act seemed wasteful. But Jesus defended her: *“Leave her alone... She has done a beautiful thing to me. She did what she could. She has anointed my body beforehand for burial”* (Mark 14:6, 8, ESV).

Only Mary saw the cross was coming. And only Mary responded in such a costly, tender way. She gave her dowry for His burial—the deepest symbol of her future, her security, her dreams—because she understood something about Jesus that others didn’t. She was the first to prepare Him for what was to come, not with theological precision, but with love. She was his friend.

And as He carried His cross, the fragrance of that nard likely lingered. The scent of her worship mingled with the blood and sweat of His sacrifice. Mary’s love followed Him to Calvary.

Her story reminds us that friendship with Jesus isn’t loud or public or always understood. It’s chosen in quiet moments, at His feet, in listening and weeping and costly offering. Mary’s life whispers to ours: *Sit. Listen. Love extravagantly. Let your life leave a fragrance that leads Jesus all the way to the cross—and beyond.*

Jesus: Withdrawing to Be Alone with the Father

It was night in the garden. Olive trees stood like silent witnesses under a sky heavy with dread. The air was thick with the scent of oil and dust, and the stillness of the hour was broken only by the sound of Jesus' breath as He knelt in the shadows. Blood and sweat mingled on His brow. His friends were nearby but asleep. The cross was ahead. And here, in Gethsemane, the full weight of surrender came into view.

“Father, if You are willing, take this cup from Me; yet not My will, but Yours be done.” (Luke 22:42)

This moment wasn't improvised. It was the pinnacle of a life cultivated in secret. The Garden of Gethsemane was not where Jesus learned to trust—it was where trust, *long practiced in solitude*, held firm beneath crushing pressure.

He had prayed here before. He had withdrawn often.

“Jesus often withdrew to lonely places and prayed.” (Luke 5:16)

Before selecting the Twelve, He spent the night in prayer. After healing crowds, He slipped away. In the early mornings and late nights, He made space to be with the Father. Even as the Son of God, He prioritized intimacy with God in solitude. This rhythm—this quiet devotion—was the wellspring of His ministry.

Jesus didn't just model how to teach or how to serve. He modeled how to commune. How to make room for the Father when no one is watching. How to return again and again to the One who sent Him.

And in Gethsemane, when the cost of obedience reached its peak, He didn't retreat from God—He leaned in. His surrender didn't come from a place of performance but from long-cultivated friendship. He had chosen the Father in the morning hours, on mountainsides, in wilderness places—and now, in the garden, He chose Him again.

From Abraham's stars to Moses' tent, from David's psalms to Mary's poured-out perfume—the conversation had continued. And now, in Jesus, it reached its fulfillment. The Son of God, in human flesh, showed us that deep friendship with the Father is possible—and powerful.

The good news? He opened that life to us. He not only died for us—He showed us how to live. Jesus invites us into the secret place. Into solitude that becomes connection. Into silence that becomes surrender. Into prayer that becomes power.

And the Father still waits there.

So withdraw. Return. Come to the garden, not only in crisis but in rhythm. Let the soil of your soul be softened by stillness. Let your

love be cultivated in quiet. Follow Jesus into the hidden place—and there, find the friendship that carries you through everything.

These Are the Conversations That Shape a Soul

Abraham questioned under the stars.

Moses pleaded in the tent.

David worshiped and wept with his lyre.

Mary poured out perfume in silence.

Jesus withdrew in the dark of night to be alone with His Father.

Each of them brought their full selves—doubts, fears, praise, questions, and surrender.

None of them performed. They prayed in intimate and private conversations with God. They poured out their hearts. And God met them there.

These weren't scripted speeches or religious obligations.

They were honest, ongoing conversations—slow-built over time, cultivated in solitude, and anchored in love.

Because prayer isn't about performance.

It's about proximity.

The people closest to God in Scripture were those who dared to stay in the conversation.

So how do we follow in their footsteps?

How do we build the kind of private prayer life that nourishes real faith instead of just checking a spiritual box?

We begin where they began:

With God's voice.

With our honesty.

With a rhythm of presence.

Start with What God Has Already Said

God's Word isn't just a record of what once was. It's an invitation to dialogue—now.

When we open Scripture, we aren't just reading ancient stories; we are stepping into a living conversation. His words stir our hearts, confront our assumptions, and awaken our questions. That's how real prayer begins.

Sometimes a single phrase will meet you right where you are.

Sometimes a parable will provoke a question you didn't know you had.

Sometimes a Psalm will echo your ache before you can put it into words.

The goal isn't just to analyze—it's to respond.

"God, this confuses me..."

“Help me believe this.”

“Show me how to live this.”

When you start with His voice, you open space for your own.

Build a Rhythm of Presence

Abraham didn’t speak with God once.

Moses returned to the tent again and again.

David’s songs filled a lifetime.

Mary sat at Jesus’ feet in peace, in sorrow, and in worship.

And Jesus—Jesus withdrew often, not just in crisis, but as a way of life.

Solitude was where intimacy was strengthened.

Stillness was where surrender was practiced.

Gethsemane was not a beginning—it was the culmination of a life deeply rooted in hidden communion.

You don’t need a perfect script or a perfect setting.

You just need to begin.

Sit still. Speak freely. Listen slowly. Return often.

This is how friendship with God is formed—not in grand gestures, but in simple, consistent, honest conversations.

So come into the quiet.

Let the flame of God's presence burn steady in your hidden life.

Let your soul be shaped—not by noise, but by nearness.

These are the conversations that will shape you, slowly and surely,
into someone who walks with God.

Practicing the Conversation: Where Faith Becomes Friendship

The stories you've just read are not distant spiritual legends—they're invitations. Each life, each quiet moment, each conversation with God points to something deeper: this is not just what *they* experienced—it's what *you* were made for.

You may not see stars like Abraham or hold a staff like Moses. You may never write psalms like David or anoint anyone with perfume like Mary. But the same God who met them in private is still drawing near today. And He's inviting you into that same kind of relationship—marked not by performance, but by presence.

So how do we begin?

How do we cultivate a prayer life that's real—not rushed, not religious, but rooted?

Here are five practices to help you step into that space and stay there. They're not formulas. They're postures—ways to keep the conversation going, so your faith can grow into friendship.

1. Respond—Don't Just Read

Reading Scripture without responding can keep God at arm's length. But when you pause and speak back—even with your doubts or questions—you step into relationship.

The Psalms model this beautifully: remembering truth, voicing frustration, declaring trust. That rhythm of response is the heartbeat of prayer.

Try This: When something you read strikes you—comforts or confronts—don't rush on. Say something. Write something. Let that moment open the door to dialogue.

2. Speak Honestly

You don't need the right words. You need your real ones.

In Gethsemane, Jesus didn't hide His pain—He brought it fully to the Father. You can too. If you're angry, say it. If you're numb, bring that. God doesn't need polish—He wants presence.

Try This: Pray raw. If all you can say is “Help,” say it. If all you can do is sit, sit. That still counts. That's still prayer.

3. Make Room for Silence

Some of the deepest parts of a relationship happen in silence. The same is true in prayer.

Elijah didn't hear God in wind or fire—but in a whisper. And whispers are only heard when we stop talking.

Try This: After you speak, sit quietly for a minute or two. Breathe. Don't force anything. Just be there. This is where presence—not productivity—starts to form your soul.

4. Bring Your Whole Life Into It

There's no part of your life that God isn't already aware of—and deeply interested in.

Jesus didn't compartmentalize prayer. Whether choosing disciples or blessing a meal, He stayed in constant conversation with the Father. That's our model: prayer not just as a moment but as a way of living.

Try This: Throughout the day, talk to God as things unfold. "What do You think?" "Why does this hurt?" "Thank You for that." Keep the line open.

5. Let the Conversation Shape You

Prayer isn't just about what you feel—it's about how you live.

The more time you spend in honest, ongoing dialogue with God, the more you'll notice shifts in how you see, think, and act. Sometimes the Word will stir conviction. Other times, a moment of silence will bring clarity. And often, it's the quiet act of returning again and again that slowly changes your default reactions and daily rhythms.

Jesus didn't just pray, "*Not My will, but Yours.*" He got up from prayer and walked toward the cross. Prayer formed His next steps.

Try This: Before you end your time of prayer, ask:
"From this time with God, what action am I being invited into?"
"What do I want to do—or stop doing—in light of what I've heard?" Let prayer become the launching point for obedience. Let your next steps flow from the sacred space you've just shared with God.

This Is Where Faith Becomes Friendship

These quiet, often unseen moments with God are not about performance or perfection. They're about **connection**. You don't need to impress Him. You just need to show up.

Let His voice begin the conversation. Bring your whole self in response. Make space for silence. Stay with it—even when you feel nothing.

Then—*from that space*—ask what your next step should be.

Because this is where faith becomes friendship.

Where listening becomes obedience.

Where presence leads to purpose.

This is how souls are shaped.

Not just in what we pray—

But in what we do next.

Chapter 6: Different Types of Conversations With God *by Hazen*

Different Ways Prayer Sounds

Not every conversation sounds the same. You don't talk to a friend the same way you talk to a doctor. You don't speak in the same tone when you're laughing as when you're grieving. The same is true in prayer.

Our conversations with God shift—depending on what we're walking through, what we're feeling, and even what we can't put into words.

Sometimes prayer is steady and peaceful. Sometimes it's raw and chaotic. Sometimes it's loud praise. Other times, it's sitting in silence with clenched fists and tear-streaked cheeks. And all of it counts. All of it belongs.

God isn't looking for one prayer tone. He's looking for honesty.

In this chapter, we're going to explore the different ways we engage God—not just through spoken words, but through every kind of

heart expression: worship, lament, thanksgiving, anger, silence, and even creativity.

Worship: When Prayer Sounds Like Praise

Sometimes prayer sounds like music.

Sometimes it sounds like a whisper of thanks, a shout of joy, or a trembling declaration of truth when you feel anything *but* strong.

Worship is more than singing—it's a posture of the heart. It's a declaration of who God is, often made *in contrast* to how we feel or what we see. It's what we say when our soul remembers that God is still good, still present, still worthy.

The phrase “*Give thanks to the Lord, for He is good; His mercy endures forever*” is one of the most repeated refrains in the entire Bible. It echoes through the Psalms, through the histories, and into eternity itself. (See Psalm 106:1, 107:1, 118:1, 2 Chronicles 5:13, Ezra 3:11, and more.)

In 2 Chronicles 20, when King Jehoshaphat faced a vast army far too great to defeat, God told him to send *worshipers* to the front lines. That's right—no swords or shields—just voices lifted in praise.

“After consulting the people, Jehoshaphat appointed men to sing to the Lord and to praise Him for the splendor of His holiness as they went

out at the head of the army, saying: ‘Give thanks to the Lord, for His love endures forever’” (2 Chronicles 20:21).

And as they worshiped, the Lord set ambushes against their enemies. Worship was not the response *after* the victory—it was the pathway *to* it. Because worship isn’t passive—it’s powerful.

And yet, worship isn’t only for moments of crisis. It is the steady rhythm of heaven.

In the Book of Revelation, we’re given a glimpse into what happens around God’s throne. Worship is constant. It’s not bound to a feeling—it’s rooted in who God is.

*“Day and night they never stop saying:
‘Holy, holy, holy
is the Lord God Almighty,
who was, and is, and is to come.’” (Revelation 4:8)*

Elders fall down. Crowns are cast. Multitudes cry out with one voice: *“Worthy is the Lamb who was slain!”* (Revelation 5:12, ESV).

Heaven doesn’t move on from worship. Neither should we.

And Jesus, even in His earthly life, modeled a life of thanksgiving and praise.

Before feeding the five thousand, He gave thanks (John 6:11).

At the Last Supper, knowing what was about to come, *He gave*

thanks (Luke 22:19).

Even as He faced the cross, He anchored Himself in the Father's goodness.

Gratitude wasn't a mood—it was a rhythm. Worship wasn't reserved for easy days—it was woven into every part of His life.

Worship doesn't ignore pain.

It reframes it.

It lifts our eyes to what is true and eternal when everything around us feels temporary and chaotic.

It reminds us that God is still God—and we are still His.

Practice:

Don't wait for a good mood to praise God.

Let worship *lead* you there.

Try beginning your prayer by naming who God is:

- *"You are faithful."*
- *"You are with me."*
- *"You are holy."*
- *"You are my defender... my provider... my peace."*

Try repeating a biblical refrain:

“The Lord is good. His mercy endures forever.”

If you’re struggling to find words, open to a Psalm or Revelation 4 or 5 and read the worship already happening in heaven. Let it carry you.

Worship is more than sound—it’s surrender. It’s an agreement. It’s love.

And when we enter that space, we don’t just remind ourselves of who God is—we join the eternal chorus that’s already surrounding His throne.

Lament: When Prayer Sounds Like Grief

Sometimes the only honest prayer is a painful one.

When the world collapses, when the losses are deep, when the answers don’t come—lament is what faithful prayer sounds like.

Lament is a deeply biblical form of prayer that brings sorrow, confusion, and raw emotion into the presence of God. It’s not polished. It’s not tidy. But it’s holy. Because lament dares to believe that God is still listening—even when He feels absent. Take a moment to hear Hannah’s testimony of lament which illustrates these principles.

“There are some pains that words cannot adequately describe. After my pregnancies, I developed debilitating back problems that eventually required emergency surgery. The weeks leading up to that operation and the month that followed were filled with the most excruciating physical pain I have ever experienced.

Pain has a way of shrinking your world until it becomes the only reality you know. My prayers, once flowing and articulate, reduced to desperate whispers: “Help me, God. Just help me through the next moment.” Sometimes even those simple words felt too complex to form. My prayer became my tears, my shallow breathing, my clenched fists in the darkness.

I remember one night in particular. The pain had kept me awake for hours, and a deeper anguish was taking hold—the fear that this might never end, that this might be my new normal. How long, Lord? How long? The question echoed through my sleepless hours until it wasn’t just about the pain anymore but about my capacity to endure it.

It was around 3 AM when something shifted. Not the pain—that remained constant—but something within me. I sensed God challenging me to lay down not just my physical discomfort but my desperate need to know the timeline, to control the outcome, to understand the purpose. For hours, I wrestled with this invitation to surrender. My grip on these questions had become a form of

control, a way of managing my fear. Letting go felt like falling into an abyss.

"I don't need to know how long," I finally whispered into the darkness. "I don't need to understand why. I just need to know You're here."

It wasn't a magical solution. The pain didn't immediately vanish. But somehow, I drifted to sleep, and in that sleep, I experienced something I cannot fully put into words—a supernatural grace, a comfort that permeated every part of my being: body, soul, and spirit.

What surprised me most about how God met me in my lament wasn't the eventual physical healing, though I'm deeply grateful for that. It was how utterly otherworldly His comfort was. Nothing in this world—no medication, no kind word, no physical relief—can approach the quality of peace that God's presence brings in our darkest moments. His comfort doesn't just change our circumstances; it changes us from within.

This experience transformed my understanding of prayer. God hears. He really does. And I've learned that the quicker we can reach that place of true desperation, the place where we lay down our frantic efforts to self-medicate or fix our situation through sheer determination, the sooner we create space for His supernatural

intervention. The surrender itself becomes the doorway through which God's presence enters."

As Hannah's testimony shows, lament isn't just a category of prayer; it's often the most honest prayer we can offer. And in that raw honesty, we discover that even our darkness becomes a place where God can be found.

Nearly one-third of the Psalms are laments. These are not prayers of doubt—they are acts of defiant trust. They turn toward God in pain rather than away from Him.

"How long, Lord? Will You forget me forever?" (Psalm 13:1)

"My God, my God, why have You forsaken me?" (Psalm 22:1, ESV)

Even Jesus prayed those words on the cross.

In the Gospel of Matthew, at the height of His suffering, Jesus cries out:

"My God, my God, why have You forsaken Me?" (Matthew 27:46)

He doesn't hide His anguish. He brings it into the open. Quoting David's lament from Psalm 22, Jesus gives voice to divine agony. And in doing so, He validates our own cries. Even the Son of God wept, questioned, and felt forsaken. Lament was His language, too.

But Jesus' lament didn't begin at the cross.

On the road to Jerusalem, Jesus paused and looked out over the city—the place He loved, the people He had come to save. And His heart broke.

“Jerusalem, Jerusalem, you who kill the prophets and stone those sent to you,

how often I have longed to gather your children together,

as a hen gathers her chicks under her wings,

and you were not willing.”

(Matthew 23:37)

This wasn’t anger. It was sorrow. It was the ache of rejected love. Jesus wasn’t lamenting His own pain—He was lamenting theirs. The missed opportunities. The resistance to grace. The refusal to be gathered.

Jesus wept for the city. For the people. For the brokenness of the world.

And in doing so, He taught us that lament isn’t just personal—it’s prophetic.

It gives voice not only to our wounds, but to the wounds of others. It makes space to grieve for what’s not as it should be.

The prophet Jeremiah, often called the “weeping prophet,” did the same. He watched his people fall. He saw the temple burn. He lived

through devastation, siege, and exile. And from that wreckage, he wrote an entire book of lament.

The book of Lamentations is a sacred journal of suffering. It's filled with deep anguish, with cries of abandonment, with honest confusion about how a good God could allow such pain.

“He has walled me in so I cannot escape; He has weighed me down with chains...

Even when I call out or cry for help, He shuts out my prayer”

(Lamentations 3:7–8).

But even there, in the heart of grief, hope flickers:

“Yet this I call to mind and therefore I have hope:

Because of the Lord’s great love we are not consumed,

for His compassions never fail. They are new every morning;

great is Your faithfulness”

(Lamentations 3:21–23).

That’s the heartbeat of lament.

Not pretending everything is fine.

Not rushing through sorrow to get to resolution.

But bringing real pain into God's presence and letting trust rise from the ashes.

Lament doesn't demand quick answers.

It doesn't skip the process.

It creates sacred space for grief.

It gives voice to wounds that don't yet have healing.

And it teaches us how to remain in relationship with God even in the dark.

Because true friendship includes hard conversations.

And God, in His grace, has made room in Scripture—and in His heart—for those who mourn. *“Blessed are those who mourn, for they will be comforted”* (Matthew 5:4).

Practice:

When you're hurting, don't sanitize your prayers.

Try writing your own psalm of lament or journaling like Jeremiah.

- Begin with complaint: *“God, where are You?”*
- Name your sorrow: *“This is what's breaking me...”*
- Let it be messy and real.

Then—if you can—end with a whisper of trust, even if it feels small:

“But I trust in Your unfailing love...” (Psalm 13:5)

“Yet this I call to mind and therefore I have hope...”

(Lamentations 3:21)

“You are still God” (Psalm 46:10).

Even if it's whispered through tears, that whisper is still worship.

And God hears it.

Anger: When Prayer Sounds Like a Fight

Yes, even anger can be prayer.

When we're frustrated—with life, with others, or even with God—it's better to bring it into the conversation than to bury it in silence.

Anger in prayer doesn't mean something is wrong with your faith. It means your faith is alive enough to protest, to plead, to wrestle. That's not rebellion—it's a relationship.

The Bible doesn't shy away from anger. In fact, some of the most powerful prayers in Scripture are born out of holy frustration.

Job, after losing nearly everything, cries out:

"Though I cry, 'Violence!' I get no response;

though I call for help, there is no justice...

God has wronged me and drawn His net around me"

(Job 19:7, 6).

Those are not polite prayers. They're raw. Accusatory. Honest. And still, God called Job *blameless* (Job 1:8) and *honest* (Job 42:7).

Jeremiah, the prophet who delivered some of God's harshest words to Israel, also turned his rage and disappointment toward heaven:

*“You deceived me, Lord, and I was deceived;
You overpowered me and prevailed.
I am ridiculed all day long; everyone mocks me”*
(Jeremiah 20:7).

Imagine speaking that way to God—and knowing He’s listening. Jeremiah felt misled, used, and overwhelmed. And he didn’t bottle it up—he brought it into prayer.

Even in the Psalms, which are often associated with worship and praise, we find deep currents of rage and confusion. Psalm 88 is perhaps the darkest of them all:

*“You have put me in the lowest pit,
in the darkest depths...
Why, Lord, do You reject me
and hide Your face from me?”*
(Psalm 88:6, 14).

There’s no resolution at the end of this psalm. No bow tied around the pain. It closes with the line: *“Darkness is my closest friend”* (Psalm 88:18, NLT).

And yet—God included it in His Word. He preserved it as Scripture. That’s His invitation to you: bring it all. Even the parts you think you’re not allowed to say.

Anger doesn't disqualify you from prayer. It may be the doorway to your most honest one.

Because the opposite of love is not anger—it's apathy. If you're still talking to God, even in your rage, it means you're still in a relationship. And that matters more than getting the words right.

Practice:

If you're angry, say it. Don't dress it up.

Don't try to spiritualize it or shut it down. Tell God the truth:

- *"I don't understand this."*
- *"I'm mad at You."*
- *"I feel betrayed."*
- *"Why did You let this happen?"*

You may not get an immediate answer. But honesty is itself an act of faith.

God doesn't flinch. He isn't offended by your honesty. He's more interested in your *real* heart than your *polished* tone.

If it helps, try writing it out as a prayer-journal entry. Or read the angry psalms aloud. Shout if you need to. Cry if you can.

Fight—but fight toward God, not away from Him.

Because even when you feel like screaming into the void—God is still listening.

And sometimes, it's the angry prayer that becomes the bridge back to deeper trust.

Silence: When Prayer Has No Words

There are seasons when the words just won't come.

Grief numbs the mouth. Confusion clutters the mind. Fatigue steals the breath. Or maybe you've prayed the same thing so many times, it starts to feel empty. Repetitive. Powerless.

In those moments, silence isn't a failure in prayer.

It *is* prayer.

The first time I encountered contemplative prayer, I was skeptical.

Having been diagnosed with ADHD as a child, my mind had always raced from one thought to the next—a perpetual storm of ideas, concerns, and distractions that made traditional prayer feel like trying to have a conversation in a crowded, noisy room.

I had just joined the staff of what would later become GateCity Church, a ministry focused on prayer and missions. Part of our commitment included spending time in our 24/7 prayer room for devotional study. It was there that Kevin, a missionary who had

been with the organization for years, began leading a weekly meditation group.

"The goal isn't to empty yourself," Kevin explained during our first session, "but to create space for God to fill." This distinction immediately resonated with me—unlike Eastern meditation practices, we weren't seeking detachment from all desires, but rather a deeper attachment to the One who created us.

I remember sitting in one of the chairs in the sanctuary that first day, Bible open in my lap, focusing on the particular verse Kevin had selected for our meditation. The first five minutes were excruciating. My thoughts pinballed between my to-do list, concerns about an upcoming event, and even what I might have for lunch. Every time I tried to focus on the Scripture, another thought would intrude.

"This is normal," Kevin assured us. "Just gently bring your attention back to the verse whenever you notice your mind has wandered. Don't judge yourself for it."

Week after week, I returned to that group, training my mental muscles like a spiritual athlete. Slowly, almost imperceptibly at first, I began to experience moments of genuine stillness—brief windows where the racing thoughts subsided and I could simply be with God.

Thomas Dubay, in his book "Fire Within," quotes St. John of the Cross: "What we need most in order to make progress is to be silent before this great God...for the language He best hears is silent love" (Dubay, *Fire Within*, 123). This truth began to take root in my heart. Prayer was transforming from a one-sided conversation where I did all the talking into a shared presence—like sitting comfortably with a dear friend, where words aren't always necessary.

This practice became especially meaningful during 2011, when our community felt called to pray for an African American missions movement to reach Muslim nations across the 10/40 Window. The scope of this prayer assignment was both vast and highly specific, and often I found traditional words utterly inadequate to express what I was carrying.

One afternoon during this season, I sat in our prayer room, attempting to articulate specific petitions for this movement. But something shifted within me as I centered my heart on God's presence. Without warning, I found myself overwhelmed with wordless weeping for unreached souls. In that moment, I understood what David Brainerd meant when he wrote in his journal: "I was in such anguish, and pleaded with so much earnestness and importunity...that when I rose from my knees I felt extremely weak and overcome...and the sweat ran down my face and body" (*The Life and Diary of David Brainerd*, 89).

This wasn't emotional manipulation or manufactured fervor—it was carrying God's own burden for the nations. Romans 8:26 in the NLT came alive for me: "And the Holy Spirit helps us in our weakness. For example, we don't know what God wants us to pray for. But the Holy Spirit prays for us with groanings that cannot be expressed in words."

The culmination of those months of intercession happened at Ford Field in Detroit, where thousands who had been praying gathered. Did our prayers make a difference? The full answer awaits eternity, but God gave us one unmistakable sign. That night, a young African American man named David, who had been living homeless, wandered into the stadium and surrendered his life to Jesus.

Months later, this same young man showed up at our ministry in Atlanta, seeking discipleship and missionary training. When he shared his testimony of that night in Detroit, I felt a holy chill run through my body. Here, standing before me, was the embodiment of what we had prayed for—a direct answer to those wordless groans.

Today, David serves faithfully in various nations as a missionary. He represents countless others whose names and faces we may never know this side of heaven, but whose lives were equally transformed through that season of prayer. As Mother Teresa once said, "God speaks in the silence of the heart" (*A Simple Path*, 72), and

sometimes, our deepest prayers are the ones where we finally stop talking and simply listen.

Learning contemplative prayer and how to carry burdens in prayer wordlessly wasn't without struggles. The busyness of my mind constantly fought against discipline. I questioned if I was "doing it right" or if the emotions that sometimes surfaced—tears, sadness, or unexpected joy—were truly from God or merely my own psychological processes. I had to develop discernment about what was from the Holy Spirit, what originated from my own soul, and what might even be interference from "your enemy the devil [who] prowls around like a roaring lion looking for someone to devour" (1 Peter 5:8, NLT).

Perhaps the most transformative contemplative prayer experience came during a season when I meditated on the shortest verse in Scripture: "Jesus wept" (John 11:35, NKJV). I had heard someone say that "the Bible is far deeper than it is long," but this experience proved it to me. Those two words became an endless well because they were connected to the living presence of the Holy Spirit.

As I sat with this verse day after day, I began to see layers I had never noticed before. Jesus wasn't merely sad about Lazarus's death—He was "deeply moved in spirit and troubled" (John 11:33, NLT). The original Greek suggests a profound groaning, an indignation against death itself. And when Jesus says, "Father, I thank You that You have

heard Me. And I know that You always hear Me, but because of the people who are standing by I said this, that they may believe that You sent Me" (John 11:41-42, NKJV), I realized He was indicating that the real prayer had already happened—in silence, in communion with the Father.

In contemplative prayer, I discovered that God doesn't need my eloquence or my many words. He desires my presence—my full, undivided attention. And in that quiet communion, I often hear His voice most clearly.

There's a depth to silence that words can't reach.

A kind of reverence. A kind of surrender.

A way of saying, *"I'm still here, God—even when I don't know what to say."*

This means the pressure is off.

You don't have to have the right words. You don't even have to *have* words.

The Spirit prays with you. The Father understands your silence. Your presence is enough.

Even in the Psalms—so full of poetic expression—there are silent moments.

In Psalm 46:10, God says,

"Be still, and know that I am God" (ESV).

That's not a call to passivity—it's a call to presence.

Stillness is not emptiness. It's expectancy.

It's waiting with open hands and an open heart.

Jesus Himself often withdrew to quiet places.

Before big decisions. After miracles. In the early morning or late at night. Even in Gethsemane, when the weight of the cross pressed on His soul, we sense long pauses between the recorded words. The kind of silence that carries surrender.

Sometimes the deepest conversations don't happen in speaking—they happen in sitting.

Practice: Be Still, and Breathe

Create space to be still for five minutes today.

- No music.
- No phone.
- No words.

Just sit with God.

When your mind wanders (and it will), don't scold yourself.

Just gently come back with a breath prayer.

What Is a Breath Prayer?

A breath prayer is a simple, sacred phrase that you repeat in rhythm with your breathing. It helps center your thoughts and focus your heart on God's presence. It's been used by Christians for centuries—especially when words are hard to find.

You can choose one short phrase of Scripture or truth and pray it slowly as you inhale and exhale.

Examples:

- Inhale: *"Be still..."*
Exhale: *"and know that I am God."*
- Inhale: *"Jesus, Son of God..."*
Exhale: *"have mercy on me."*
- Inhale: *"You are here..."*
Exhale: *"I am Yours."*

Let the rhythm of your breath carry the truth of God's nearness.

Let the silence hold you.

Let the Spirit pray for you.

Let God's presence be enough—even when your prayers are wordless.

Because sometimes, silence speaks love the loudest.

Wrestling in Prayer: My Own Experience

I've had times in prayer where I've felt full of faith and joy—and times where I felt like I was shouting into a void. I've asked God for things that didn't happen. I've sat in silence for weeks. I've cried in anger. I've worshipped when it made no sense. And I've learned: God stays in the conversation.

I remember once sitting in a dark room, deeply confused and feeling abandoned by God. I had no words. Just tears. I eventually whispered, "*Are You even here?*" And, in that moment, I didn't get an answer—but I felt held. That was a conversation. Wordless, but real.

These aren't categories to master—they're movements of the soul. And every one of them is welcome in God's presence.

God Meets You in Every Type of Prayer

Your conversation with God doesn't have to sound like anyone else's.

It won't always be neat.

It won't always be emotional.

It won't always be clear.

But if it's honest—it's holy.

Whatever season you're in—joy, sorrow, gratitude, grief, confusion, creativity—there's a way to talk to God from that place. Or simply be with Him in it.

The point isn't to say the right thing.

The point is to *stay in the conversation*.

Because this is where faith becomes friendship.

This is where souls are shaped.

One honest prayer at a time.

Chapter 7: When Prayer flows from Creative Expression *By Hazen*

Now let's dive a little deeper into one aspect of conversation with God, with a special chapter dedicated to discovering the unique place of creativity in our conversations with God!

As we discovered in the last chapter, not all prayer is spoken. We often think of prayer as words—spoken aloud or whispered in quiet moments, structured in phrases or poured out in desperation. But the God who created galaxies with breath, who sculpted humans from dust, who wove beauty into every corner of creation, is not limited to language. He is the Artist of all artists. And when we create, reflect, or express what's inside us with honesty, we mirror His image. That reflection—offered to Him—can become a sacred form of prayer.

God is the Creator. And we, made in His image, are creators too.

From the very beginning, God wove creativity into the story of worship. In Exodus, He filled artisans with His Spirit to craft the Tabernacle—a dwelling place for His presence among His people. Scripture names Bezalel and Oholiab, whom God equipped with

“skill, ability, and knowledge in all kinds of crafts—to make artistic designs for work in gold, silver and bronze, to cut and set stones, to work in wood, and to engage in all kinds of craftsmanship” (Exodus 31:3–5, NLT).

The Tabernacle wasn’t just a structure—it was an embodied prayer. Through textiles, embroidery, metalwork, incense blending, wood carving, and architectural design, worship took form. Creativity was not separate from devotion; it was the *vessel* of it.

That same Spirit who inspired the artisans of old still fills us today.

I’ve had moments where I couldn’t speak a word in prayer—but I wrote page after page in my journal, pouring out my heart, unsure if it “counted” as prayer. Looking back, I know it did. Other times, I’ve picked up a guitar and sung to God without polished words, just sound and heart. On occasion I’ve even stood in front of a canvas, painting as a way to meet the One who understands the language of color better than anyone.

God doesn’t require eloquence. He asks for presence. He invites us to come as we are, not just in quiet moments but in our expressions—in our creativity, our movement, our stillness.

Creativity doesn’t have to be a side hobby; it can be a doorway to divine connection. It’s not about being good at it—it’s about being real in it.

Creative Prayer Practices: Speaking with God Through Art

Prayer is a conversation—but conversations don't always happen in words. Sometimes, the deepest dialogues with God rise through brushstrokes, melodies, movement, or symbols.

In my journey of faith, I've discovered that there are moments when words alone cannot carry the full weight of what our hearts want to express to God. It is in these moments that creative expression becomes not merely an artistic endeavor but a profound form of prayer itself. My own experience with this began unexpectedly during a pivotal season of spiritual renewal.

During my first year coming back to faith, I felt a deep hunger to communicate with God in ways that transcended my limited vocabulary. Traditional prayers sometimes felt constrained, unable to express the complex emotions unfolding within me. Almost instinctively, I picked up a guitar and began teaching myself to play—not as a performance skill, but as a vehicle for conversation with God.

What emerged surprised me. As I strummed simple chords and allowed melodies to form spontaneously, I found myself touching depths of worship, lament, and adoration that my journaled prayers

had never reached. I wrote songs in those days—raw, unpolished, but achingly sincere—that poured out my heart in ways my spoken prayers never could. These musical prayers became a sanctuary where my spirit could communicate directly with God beyond the limitations of structured language.

I recorded some of these songs during that season and listened to them from time to time over the years. They capture the beauty of that first-love fire that I never want to lose. What strikes me now is how these creative expressions have preserved those sacred moments. While my journal entries from that time read like historical documents, when I play those recordings, the emotion and presence of those moments flood back with startling immediacy. This is one of the profound gifts of creative prayer—it doesn't merely describe our spiritual journey; it embodies it.

There's something deeply moving about knowing these artistic expressions will transcend generations. Perhaps my grandchildren will one day hear these old iPhone recordings of the songs grandpa wrote when he first fell in love with Jesus. They might encounter not just stories about my faith, but experience a window into the actual emotion and passion of those formative moments. This is the beauty of creative expressions in prayer—they go beyond words to express beauty and passion in ways that touch the human heart differently and are often shareable across time and space.

This divine connection between creativity and spiritual communion isn't a modern innovation—it's woven into the very fabric of Scripture. In fact, it's revealing that the first people specifically described as being "filled with the Spirit of God" in the Bible were not prophets or priests, but artists and craftspeople. In Exodus 35, as the tabernacle—God's dwelling place among His people—was being prepared, we read:

"Then Moses said to the Israelites, 'See, the Lord has chosen Bezalel son of Uri, the son of Hur, of the tribe of Judah, and he has filled him with the Spirit of God, with wisdom, with understanding, with knowledge and with all kinds of skills—to make artistic designs for work in gold, silver and bronze, to cut and set stones, to work in wood and to engage in all kinds of artistic crafts. And he has given both him and Oholiab son of Ahisamak, of the tribe of Dan, the ability to teach others. He has filled them with skill to do all kinds of work as engravers, designers, embroiderers in blue, purple and scarlet yarn and fine linen, and weavers—all of them skilled workers and designers.'" (Exodus 35:30-35)

This passage reveals something profound: God's Spirit specifically empowered creativity for the purpose of creating sacred space. The artistic expressions of these craftspeople weren't mere decorations; they were divinely inspired prayers in physical form, creating an

environment where heaven and earth could meet. Their creativity became the very dwelling place of God's presence.

This pattern of creative expression as spiritual communication continues throughout church history. While the sermons of John Wesley formed the theological backbone of the Wesleyan and Methodist denominations, it is his brother Charles' hymns that continue to be sung week after week around the world. Charles Wesley wrote over 6,500 hymns, and many—like "Hark! The Herald Angels Sing" and "Christ the Lord Is Risen Today"—remain staples of Christian worship nearly three centuries later. Today, an estimated 20 million people sing Wesley's hymns each year in churches spanning every continent and dozens of denominations.

This illustrates a profound truth about creative prayer and worship: while theological treatises speak primarily to the intellect, artistic expressions of faith engage our entire being—heart, mind, soul, and strength. They become vehicles through which our deepest devotion can flow in ways that transcend cultural and generational boundaries.

As we explore the various forms of creative prayer in this chapter, I invite you to consider how your own conversation with God might expand beyond traditional words. Whether through music, visual arts, dance, poetry, or countless other expressions, the creative impulse itself reflects the image of our Creator God. When we create

as an act of prayer, we participate in a holy conversation that has been ongoing since humans first lifted their voices in songs of praise and painted images of divine encounter on cave walls.

Creative expression in prayer isn't an alternative to traditional prayer—it's an expansion of it, opening channels of communication with God that might otherwise remain closed. As we'll discover together, these expressions often become not just personal prayers but shared conversations that invite others into encounters with the Divine.

Here are a few creative practices to help you explore that sacred connection:

Visual Journaling & Mixed Media

Blend writing, sketching, painting, or collage into a single space. Use colors and layers to express what words can't.

Why it matters: The process of creating becomes a prayer in itself. Each line or layer can carry a part of your soul offered honestly to God.

Poetic & Musical Expression

Write or speak poetry, sing spontaneously, or play an instrument to express your prayers. These may be simple phrases, improvised songs, or quiet humming.

Why it matters: Music and poetry give voice to emotions and longings beyond logic. They allow your spirit to speak directly to God's heart.

Embodied & Movement Prayer

Use physical movement—like walking, dancing, swaying, kneeling, or stretching—to connect with God. You can follow music or simply move in stillness.

Why it matters: Movement is a language of surrender, joy, and intercession. Your body can express worship and prayer in powerful, unspoken ways.

Seeing & Photographing with Prayerful Eyes

Use a camera or phone to go on a “prayer walk,” capturing moments that stir your heart—light on water, weathered wood, the eyes of a friend.

Why it matters: This practice trains you to *see* God in the ordinary and to respond to Him with gratitude, wonder, or intercession.

Invitation to Create:

Take a moment and ask yourself: *How do I most naturally express what's within me?* Start there. Don't worry about skill or formality. Simply invite God into the process. Whether it's quiet or vibrant, simple or layered, let it become a sacred space. Let your creativity become prayer. Let your expression become communion.

Conclusion: The Endless Conversation

As we conclude this exploration of creativity as prayer, I'm reminded of the beautiful paradox at its core: our most profound expressions to God often emerge not from rigid formulas, but from the authentic overflow of hearts made in His creative image. What began as my simple strumming on a borrowed guitar has become a lifelong understanding that creativity isn't peripheral to spiritual life—it's essential to it.

Throughout history, humanity's most enduring artistic achievements have often been born from this sacred conversation

with the divine. Johann Sebastian Bach, who inscribed "Soli Deo Gloria" (Glory to God Alone) on his compositions, created over 1,100 works that continue to move hearts nearly three centuries later. His St. Matthew Passion and Mass in B Minor weren't merely artistic achievements—they were profound prayers expressing the deepest mysteries of faith. Bach once said, "The aim and final end of all music should be none other than the glory of God and the refreshment of the soul."

Similarly, when Michelangelo spent four years on his back painting the Sistine Chapel ceiling, he wasn't merely fulfilling a commission—he was engaged in an extended act of worship. His brushstrokes depicting the Creation and Fall of Man became a visual theology that has spoken to over 25 million visitors annually for more than 500 years. In stone and paint, Michelangelo prayed with his hands, creating conversations about God's nature that words alone could never express.

Even in our modern era, we've witnessed this tradition continue. When Mel Gibson directed "The Passion of the Christ," he wasn't simply making a film but offering an intensely personal expression of his faith. Despite industry skepticism, this cinematic prayer reached over 600 million viewers worldwide and inspired countless conversations about the redemptive sacrifice at Christianity's core. Gibson described the project as "a labor of love," revealing how

creativity becomes most powerful when flowing from authentic spiritual devotion.

These monumental works remind us that creative prayer isn't bound by scale or skill. The same holy impulse that drove Bach to compose complex fugues might lead you to hum a simple melody of praise. The passion that compelled Michelangelo to transform marble into the transcendent "Pietà" might inspire your sketch in a prayer journal. What matters isn't artistic mastery but authentic expression.

The creative prayer practices we've discussed—visual journaling, poetic expression, embodied prayer in music, and prayerful seeing with photography and visual arts—are not techniques to master but invitations to encounter. They open doors to conversations with God that might otherwise remain closed, allowing parts of our souls to speak that have long been silent.

What makes creative prayer so powerful is that it bypasses our tendency to overthink, to edit ourselves before God. When we practice creative prayer, we often surprise ourselves with the honesty that emerges—grief we didn't know we carried, joy we'd forgotten to celebrate, questions we'd been afraid to ask. And in that raw authenticity, we discover God waiting, not with judgment but with understanding that surpasses our comprehension.

I've found that these creative conversations with God often become treasured milestones in our spiritual journeys. The psalm penned in desperation, the dance offered in celebration, the image captured in wonder—these become sacred markers of divine encounters, testimonies that transcend time. They remind us not just of what we believed about God in those moments, but of how we experienced Him.

Perhaps most beautifully, creative prayer invites us into the very nature of God Himself. The Creator who spoke galaxies into existence, who designed the intricate patterns of a snowflake, who composed the distinct song of each bird—this is the One who delights when we create as prayer. When we create with and for Him, we participate in the ongoing creativity of God in the world.

As you leave this chapter, I encourage you to release any expectation of perfection in your creative prayer. Remember, the value isn't in the artistic merit of what you produce—it's in the honest offering of it. The most powerful prayers often come not from polished performance but from stuttering hearts finding their voice.

Begin where you are. Start with what moves you. Let your creativity become a conversation, whether through color or sound, movement or words, digital pixels or handmade textures. In doing so, you join a lineage of faithful creators—from Bezalel crafting the tabernacle to David composing psalms, from Bach's sacred cantatas to Wesley's

enduring hymns—who discovered that sometimes, the deepest prayers aren't spoken but created.

The language of creativity speaks where words end. It gives voice to wonder too vast for sentences, grief too deep for paragraphs, and joy too expansive for phrases. In these expressions, we find not just another way to talk to God, but a fuller, more human way to be with God.

And isn't that, after all, what prayer has always been about? Not performing religious duty, but being fully present—with our whole selves—before the One who created us for relationship with Him. So create. Express. Offer. And in doing so, discover the God who has been waiting to meet you in these sacred conversations without words.

Chapter 8: Shared Conversations When Prayer Becomes a “We” *by Hazen*

Prayer is deeply personal—but it was never meant to only be private.

From the earliest pages of Scripture, prayer is not merely a solitary act, but a collective expression. In moments of desperation, celebration, repentance, and revival, God’s people didn’t just cry out in isolation—they lifted their voices together. In *Exodus 2:23*, it says, “The Israelites groaned in their slavery and cried out, and their cry for help... went up to God.” In *Acts 4*, after Peter and John were released from interrogation, the early church “raised their voices together in prayer to God” (*Acts 4:24*). And in *Revelation 8:4*, the prayers of the saints rise collectively like incense before the throne. These images tell us something essential: prayer is meant to be shared.

We encounter God personally, but we experience Him more fully in community. He doesn’t just form isolated believers—He shapes a people. He fills not only hearts but houses. Prayer is one of the primary ways He does it.

And this was made unmistakably clear through Jesus.

The Lord's Prayer as Liturgy

When His disciples asked, “Lord, teach us to pray,” He didn’t offer a private mantra or mystical formula. He gave them a shared prayer—a framework not only for individual devotion but for collective communion. It begins with the word *Our*.

“Our Father in heaven, hallowed be Your name...”
(*Matthew 6:9*).

From the very first word, Jesus roots prayer in relationship—not only with God, but with one another. The prayer is communal by design. It doesn’t say “*my* Father,” or “my daily bread,” or “my trespasses.” Every line is woven with “we” and “us.” This is not a solo performance. It is a chorus.

This shared language brings us to the powerful concept of liturgy. Liturgy, at its core, simply means “*the work of the people*.” It refers to a set form or pattern of worship and prayer used to guide God’s people into sacred rhythms. Far from being dry routine, liturgy—when prayed with intention—forms our hearts and orients our lives toward God and one another.

Church historian Hughes Oliphant Old notes that “already in the Didache (c. A.D. 50–70), the early Christian community was praying the Lord’s Prayer three times daily.” This gives us one of the

earliest glimpses into Christian liturgy—a prayer not just recited, but rehearsed into the very rhythm of daily life and communal gatherings. Across Catholic, Orthodox, and Protestant traditions, the Lord’s Prayer remains the most universally prayed liturgy in all of Christian history.

Why? Because it forms us.

It teaches us to begin with worship, surrender our wills, ask for provision, extend forgiveness, seek deliverance, and give glory. It teaches us how to approach God together.

That’s why in our own virtual prayer meetings, we’ve adopted a simple liturgical rhythm—not rigid, but guiding.

We call it **Up, In, and Out**:

Up in worship and adoration.

In through personal reflection and repentance.

Out into the world in intercession and mission.

It’s a pattern that mirrors the Lord’s Prayer.

“Hallowed be Your name” — Up.

“Forgive us our debts” — In.

“Your kingdom come... deliver us from evil” — Out.

These rhythms—whether ancient or modern—help guide our scattered thoughts and unify our diverse hearts. Whether we’re in a

sanctuary, on Zoom, or around a kitchen table, we are shaped as a people when we pray together.

So, in this chapter, we'll walk through the Lord's Prayer again—but not just as individuals. We'll see how this ancient liturgy becomes a contemporary roadmap for communities learning to pray with one voice. Because when prayer becomes a *we*, heaven listens—and earth is changed.

1. Worship and Reverence

“Our Father in heaven, hallowed be Your name”

Every shared prayer begins with shared awe. Before we ask God for anything, we remember who He is. When we call Him “Father,” we are affirming both His nearness and His care. When we say “in heaven,” we honor His transcendence and authority. And when we hallow His name, we lift it high above every other.

In a world full of noise and opinions, shared worship quiets us. It realigns us. It reminds us that prayer is not centered on us—it is centered on God. Naming who He is together helps reframe everything else we might pray.

Practice: Begin every group prayer by naming God's character aloud together. Speak His names: “You are our Provider... our

Peace... our Shepherd.” Let worship become the doorway into God’s presence.

2. Alignment with Heaven

“Your Kingdom come”

When we pray this line, we are inviting heaven’s reality to invade our earthly one. This is a surrender of control and a cry for transformation. It is a declaration that we want God’s ways, not our own.

In shared prayer, this line becomes a unifying cry. Together, we set aside personal preferences and cultural pressures. We long for something greater: for justice to roll down, for mercy to rise up, for peace to reign, and for righteousness to take root. We pray not to preserve our comfort but to pursue God’s cause.

Practice: Consider and reflect together: What does God’s Kingdom look like in our neighborhood? In our nation? In our lives? Then pray for those realities to break in.

3. Intercession and Surrender

“Your will be done, on earth as it is in heaven”

This is the turning point from reverence to participation. It is where we not only align with God’s values but ask for courage to carry

them out. We aren't just praying for God to move—we're offering ourselves to move with Him.

In shared prayer, this is often the most passionate moment. We begin to intercede—for the broken, the lost, the sick, the suffering. We pray for leaders, cities, schools, and families. And we invite God to reorder our desires according to His greater wisdom.

Practice: Ask: “God, what are You doing in our community, and how can we join You?” Then listen together. Pray not just for outcomes but for obedience.

4. Provision and Confession

“Give us this day our daily bread... and forgive us
our debts”

This part of the prayer grounds us in our humanity. It brings our needs to the table—and not just individual needs, but shared ones. We pray for daily bread: for physical provision, emotional strength, mental clarity, spiritual nourishment. We also pray for forgiveness—not only for personal sins, but communal shortcomings.

Shared prayer becomes a place of mutual dependence and mutual grace. We don't just ask for our needs to be met—we carry one

another's burdens. We name where we've missed the mark. And we receive the mercy of God together.

Practice: Take turns naming real needs and real confessions—out loud. Ask: “Where do we need God to meet us today?” “Where do we as a people need restoration?” Then pray for God's provision and healing.

5. Deliverance and Dependence

“Lead us not into temptation, but deliver us from evil”

Here, we acknowledge the reality of spiritual battle. We are not immune to temptation. We are not unaware of the enemy's schemes. But we do not face them alone. In corporate prayer, we surround one another with spiritual covering.

We name the lies that need breaking. We declare the truth that needs remembering. We stand in the gap for those in crisis or struggle. Together, we say: “We will not walk this path alone. We will lift each other up.”

Practice: Invite people to name battles they're facing. Pray for deliverance, not with fear, but with faith. Speak the promises of God over one another with boldness.

6. Confidence and Praise

“For Yours is the Kingdom, the power, and the glory forever”

Prayer should always end with perspective. This closing is not a polite sign-off. It is a declaration of faith. No matter what we’ve prayed, we declare: the Kingdom belongs to God. The power is His. The glory is His. And nothing can stop His plan.

Ending shared prayer this way fills the room with hope. It lifts our eyes from what we lack to what He promises. It reminds us that we are not praying to a distant deity but to a reigning King.

Practice: End with spoken praise. Invite everyone to declare: “God, You reign. You are worthy. You are with us.” Let worship rise as the final word.

The Power of Shared Prayer

Something sacred happens when the people of God pray together. It’s more than emotional connection—it’s spiritual alignment. It’s the presence of God filling not just hearts, but entire spaces. It’s the church becoming more than an audience—it becomes an altar.

Jesus didn’t just teach *you* to pray. He taught *us*.

And in doing so, He invited us into something deeper than personal devotion. He invited us into a shared formation: into a rhythm of listening, asking, receiving, and declaring that is shaped by the whole Body.

So gather. Cry out. Intercede. Listen. Wait. Hope. Do it together.

Because when we lift our voices as one, we don't just reflect heaven—we welcome it.

Solemn Assemblies: A Call to Gather and Return

Throughout Scripture, when the people of God drifted into spiritual complacency or faced overwhelming crisis, God didn't send them away individually to figure things out—He called them together. These were not moments for personal reflection alone; they were solemn assemblies, sacred gatherings that invited whole communities to return to the Lord with one heart and one voice.

These assemblies were not casual or convenient. They were marked by fasting, weeping, repentance, and intercession. The call wasn't to entertainment or information but to transformation. Joel 2 offers one of the most vivid pictures:

“Blow the trumpet in Zion, declare a holy fast, call a sacred assembly... Let the priests, who minister before

the Lord, weep between the portico and the altar. Let them say, ‘Spare your people, Lord’” (Joel 2:15–17).

The beauty of a solemn assembly is not just in its collective humility but in God’s response to it. In Joel’s prophecy, the call to return is met with a promise:

“Then the Lord was jealous for His land and took pity on His people... I will repay you for the years the locusts have eaten” (Joel 2:18,25).

Solemn assemblies are not about emotional highs or dramatic moments. They are about realignment. A return. A sacred act of group humility that invites divine restoration. This isn’t a one-time event—it’s a pattern of return that God honors.

While corporate prayer takes many forms, there are certain moments when unified gatherings create a unique atmosphere where God’s presence seems especially tangible. I experienced this firsthand in a way that forever changed my understanding of corporate prayer.

In 2007, shortly before my wife and I were to be married, I felt God challenge me to do an extended fast leading up to a large gathering of prayer and worship—a “Solemn Assembly” in Nashville that summer. The only problem was I had never fasted before, much less done an extended fast, and I kept breaking it on peanut butter sandwiches every few days. I felt that God wanted me to fast for

freedom in a particular area in my life I had struggled with, and I didn't want to carry that addiction into my marriage.

Yet even though I failed miserably in my fasting, when the day arrived God met me profoundly. It was in a moment of "pre-worship" before the main events of the program even began. I was in an upper seat far away from the stage. It was uncomfortably hot in an outdoor stadium in July. They started to play a song where the chorus is "More love, more power, more of You in my life..."

As we sang this simple song, something unusual happened to me, and I began to break down and sob more deeply than I ever had before in my life. Something deep and powerful was happening related to the area where I had been asking God for freedom, and I knew healing from shame was coming to my heart. After sobbing, and snorting, and wailing—so much so that the strangers around me actually turned and quietly began to pray for me, sensing the holiness of the moment and wanting to agree—I was a different person.

It wasn't just the moment, but the movement of prayer and worship (performed weakly, I might add) that unlocked a life-changing moment where God marked me. The prayers of others culminated in the release of God's power on my life in that moment. I have been a believer in these kinds of seasons and movements of prayer, and a planner of similar events ever since, because my life was marked at

one. God has used me to be a part of hosting other gatherings of thousands where others' lives have been changed in a similar manner.

Through this profound experience, I gained personal insight into why solemn assemblies carry such spiritual potency. Beyond the theological principles I've outlined earlier in this chapter, I experienced firsthand how the collective expectancy of thousands creates an atmosphere of holy anticipation. The extended nature of these gatherings allowed my distracted heart time to truly become present to God in a way brief prayer moments rarely achieve.

Most significantly, I discovered that God's timing is sovereignly perfect in these gatherings. He orchestrates who will be present and what they need in that moment—I came desperately seeking freedom, while others around me came with their own deep needs. Despite my weakness and failed fasting attempts, God met me exactly where I was. The communal environment of worship and prayer became the setting where His healing power broke through in a way I couldn't have experienced alone.

If My People...

This theme echoes across generations. In 2 Chronicles 7:14, God doesn't just issue an invitation—He offers a covenantal promise:

“If My people, who are called by My name, will humble themselves and pray and seek My face and turn from their wicked ways, then I will hear from heaven, and I will forgive their sin and will heal their land.”

This isn't a quick fix. It's not a formula. It's a roadmap for repentance and restoration. It begins with humility—a community-wide posture of dependency. It moves to prayer—not polished, performative prayer, but desperate, united seeking. It requires repentance—a real turning from sin. And then, God promises to respond.

The healing isn't just for the individual soul—it's for communities. For churches. For cities. For nations. Solemn assemblies are not about religious display. They are about collective surrender. And God meets surrendered people with healing presence.

Acts 2: The Church Was Born in a Prayer Meeting

The early church wasn't birthed through marketing, leadership strategy, or human initiative. It was birthed in the furnace of unified prayer.

“When the day of Pentecost came, they were all together in one place... All of them were filled with the Holy Spirit” (Acts 2:1,4).

Before Peter preached. Before the crowds gathered. Before thousands were saved. There was a room full of believers waiting on the Lord together. They didn’t know what was coming, but they knew who they were waiting for.

And God answered.

That rhythm continued. In Acts 4, when they were threatened and persecuted, they didn’t scatter in fear. They gathered again in prayer:

“They raised their voices together in prayer to God... ‘Lord, consider their threats and enable your servants to speak your word with great boldness’” (Acts 4:24,29). “After they prayed, the place where they were meeting was shaken” (Acts 4:31).

This is what happens when the church prays together: fear is replaced by boldness. Spaces are shaken. And the Kingdom advances.

Small Group Prayer: Where Agreement Becomes Power

Not every prayer gathering is a solemn assembly or an upper room. Sometimes it's just a few people in a living room or coffee shop. But those spaces matter profoundly to God.

Jesus made this staggering promise:

“If two of you on earth agree about anything they ask for, it will be done for them by My Father in heaven. For where two or three gather in My name, there am I with them” (Matthew 18:19–20).

There is spiritual power in agreement. Small group prayer isn't small to heaven. It's where the Body of Christ becomes a living expression of unity, empathy, intercession, and encouragement. It's where trust is built. Where burdens are shared. Where the unseen becomes seen, and the unheard becomes heard.

In these spaces, people find their voices. They borrow faith from one another. They remember that God isn't distant. He is Emmanuel, present in every whispered prayer and honest cry.

Our Weekly Virtual Prayer Meetings

For us, shared prayer isn't just theology—it's rhythm. Every week, across different time zones and homes, we gather virtually to seek God together. We are scattered geographically but united spiritually.

These gatherings aren't polished or flashy. They are sacred. They are rooms of expectation, filled with real people and real needs.

Sometimes we pray boldly. Sometimes we wait quietly. Sometimes we celebrate. Sometimes we grieve. But in every meeting, we create space for God to move.

Over time, these rhythms have done something deep in us. They have formed a culture of prayer—a community of shared listening, discernment, and intercession. They have reminded us that prayer doesn't need a stage to be powerful. It just needs people who are willing to show up.

Why Shared Conversations Matter

When we pray together, something shifts. Our faith grows. Our hearts soften. Our vision expands. We remember we are part of something far greater than ourselves.

Shared prayer teaches us that:

- God speaks through His people.
- Agreement in prayer multiplies spiritual authority.
- Revival is birthed in unity and sustained in humility.

Jesus taught us to pray, “Our Father...” Even in solitude, we belong to a praying people. Shared conversations are not optional. They are foundational.

Closing Reflection: Gather, Pray, Expect

From the trumpet blast in Joel to the fire of Pentecost, from ancient temple courts to today’s living rooms and Zoom calls—God continues to honor a praying people.

Not because of eloquence. Not because of performance. But because of hunger. Because of humility. Because of faith.

So we gather. We pray. We expect.

Because when the people of God humble themselves and seek His face—He hears. He forgives. And He heals.

Chapter 9: Conversation With Each Other That Form Us *by Hannah*

Whether it's with God or with others, our relationships are built or broken in conversation. We can't expect deep connection if our words are shallow, reactive, or absent. The Bible doesn't just call us to love—it shows us how to love in the way we speak, listen, ask, and respond.

This chapter isn't about becoming perfect speakers. It's about becoming present people—people who value others enough to engage fully. People who model their words after Jesus: truthful, gracious, curious, and healing.

Because conversation isn't just talk. It's how relationships grow.

I haven't always been good with words. In fact, learning how to speak the truth in love has been one of the most painful and sanctifying parts of my journey. For much of my life, I found myself swinging between two extremes—either I withheld what I really thought because I didn't know how to say it kindly, or I spoke honestly but with a bluntness that left others hurting. Both patterns

came from fear: fear of disappointing others, fear of not being heard, fear of being misunderstood. But neither reflected the heart of Jesus.

Over time—and through many hard conversations, including with my family—I’ve had to learn the slow, refining work of letting my words be shaped by both courage and compassion. It’s still a work in progress. But as I’ve grown as a wife, mother, pastor and listened to God and others in quieter, more prayerful ways, I’ve found that the Spirit really does want to help us speak in ways that build up instead of tear down. These principles in this chapter aren’t just ideas I admire—they’ve been a lifeline in my own formation. Honest speech that is seasoned with grace is a mark of maturity. And I’m learning that sanctification doesn’t silence our voice—it purifies it.

Prayer may be the beginning of divine dialogue, but it is not the end. From the garden to the early church, we see that God doesn’t just speak to individuals in isolation—He forms communities through conversation. Words spoken in faith, in love, in truth, and in humility are the building blocks of deep and lasting relationships.

In fact, the New Testament contains over 50 commands that follow the pattern of “do this for one another.” These “one another” passages are not optional extras—they are foundational practices for what it means to follow Jesus together.

These commands fall into several key categories:

- **Love one another** – the most repeated instruction in the New Testament (John 13:34, 1 John 4:7)
- **Encourage and build one another up** – words that strengthen faith (1 Thess. 5:11)
- **Bear with, forgive, and be kind to one another** – when relationships are tested (Eph. 4:2, 32)
- **Submit to one another and honor one another** – expressions of humility and mutual respect (Rom. 12:10, Eph. 5:21)
- **Admonish, teach, and spur one another on** – truth spoken in love for the sake of growth (Col. 3:16, Heb. 10:24)

These verses remind us that life together is the proving ground of our faith. Jesus said it clearly:

“By this everyone will know that you are my disciples, if you love one another” (John 13:35).

In other words, the world will not recognize that we belong to Jesus by the eloquence of our prayers or the depth of our theological knowledge—but by the way we treat one another. Our everyday conversations—how we speak, listen, confess, forgive, and

serve—become some of the clearest evidence of Christ at work in our midst.

In my role as a trained spiritual director, I've had the privilege of witnessing what happens when someone feels deeply listened to. Spiritual direction is a practice of sacred listening—it's not counseling, advice-giving, or fixing. It's sitting with someone in prayerful attentiveness, helping them notice and respond to the movement of God in their life. It's a ministry of presence, not performance.

When I first discovered spiritual direction, I felt like I'd found home. I was drawn to it because of how rich and holy conversations can be—especially the ones that help people encounter God in the midst of their ordinary questions, longings, and wounds. Now, years into this practice, it has become one of my favorite things to do. In these slow, Spirit-led dialogues, I've seen people come alive to God's voice. I've watched tears open doors, and silence become a sanctuary. I've learned that the best conversations are not the ones where we find answers, but where we become more attentive to Presence.

This chapter reflects so much of what I've come to cherish about spiritual direction: the power of honest words, the courage of confession, the need for grace, and the gift of simply being present with each other. Good conversation is not a human invention—it's a divine invitation. And when we learn to talk with one another like

Christ talks with us, something sacred happens. We grow. We change. We become more like Him—together.

I've learned this most vividly not in a classroom or small group circle, but in my marriage. Hazen and I love each other fiercely—but we've also had to fight for good communication. Our best conversations have been vulnerable, tender, and sometimes hard. We've had nights of tears and frustration and mornings where forgiveness had to be a choice before it became a feeling. We've had lighthearted banter and flirting over coffee. We've misread each other's tone, misunderstood motives, and sometimes gone silent when we should have leaned in. But we've also prayed through tension, repented in whispers, and rediscovered joy by simply staying at the table together. And every time we keep showing up with honesty and grace, we're reminded: love isn't just sustained by affection—it's *sustained by conversation*.

If our kitchen-table conversations have taught me anything, it's this: the Gospel comes alive not in the abstract, but in real community. That's why the words of Dietrich Bonhoeffer have always resonated with me deeply.

Few voices have captured this truth more profoundly than Dietrich Bonhoeffer, the German pastor and theologian who served the underground Confessing Church during the rise of Nazi Germany. At a time when the official state church had aligned itself with

Hitler, Bonhoeffer helped lead a hidden seminary in Finkenwalde—an act of spiritual resistance marked by secrecy, sacrifice, and profound dependence on God.

In 1938, in the midst of increasing persecution, he wrote *Life Together*, a book forged in the crucible of danger and formed by deep experience in Christian community. It is not a sentimental reflection on fellowship—it is a call to discipleship through the shared life of faith. His insights on humility, confession, spiritual practices, and mutual care carry even greater weight when we consider the context in which they were written.

Bonhoeffer didn't write from a place of safety. The seminary he helped lead was eventually shut down by the Gestapo. He and his students lived under the threat of arrest, betrayal, and violence. Yet in that environment, he discovered something unshakable:

“Christian brotherhood is not an ideal we must realize; it is rather a reality created by God in Christ in which we may participate.”

In other words, Christian community isn't something we build with our own strength—it's something already established in Christ. Our job is to receive it, preserve it, and walk in it with grace and truth.

This chapter explores what it means to participate in conversations that don't just inform us but transform us. Because how we speak to

one another—especially within the Body of Christ—is a deeply visible and tangible way we live out the Gospel in real life.

Let's step into the dialogue—together.

Ways we Converse

Just as our relationship with God grows through meaningful dialogue, our relationships with people grow—or fall apart—based on how we speak and listen. Good conversation isn't just a skill. It's a reflection of love, humility, and the willingness to connect. The Bible gives us both instruction and example when it comes to human dialogue. If we want stronger relationships, families, and communities, we need to learn how to talk—and listen—like Christ.

In other words, the world will not know we belong to Jesus by how eloquently we pray or how much Scripture we know—but by how we treat each other. Our conversations—how we speak, listen, confess, forgive, and serve—are the clearest evidence of Christ at work within us.

Scripture gives us clear and practical ways we are to speak to one another. These are not suggestions; they are relational commands rooted in the character of God:

- **Speak the truth in love** - *“Instead, speaking the truth in love, we will grow to become in every respect the mature body of him who is the head, that is, Christ.”* —Ephesians 4:15
- **Encourage one another daily** - *“But encourage one another daily, as long as it is called ‘Today,’ so that none of you may be hardened by sin’s deceitfulness.”* —Hebrews 3:13
- **Build one another up** - *“Therefore encourage one another and build each other up, just as in fact you are doing.”* —1 Thessalonians 5:11
- **Admonish one another with wisdom** - *“Let the message of Christ dwell among you richly as you teach and admonish one another with all wisdom...”* —Colossians 3:16
- **Speak with grace, seasoned with salt** - *“Let your conversation be always full of grace, seasoned with salt, so that you may know how to answer everyone.”* —Colossians 4:6
- **Do not grumble against one another** - *“Don’t grumble against one another, brothers and sisters, or you will be judged. The Judge is standing at the door!”* —James 5:9
- **Confess your sins to one another** - *“Therefore confess your sins to each other and pray for each other so that you may be healed.”* —James 5:16

- **Comfort one another** - *“Encourage one another, be of one mind, live in peace. And the God of love and peace will be with you.”* —2 Corinthians 13:11

How we converse with one another really matters to God. Our words can become instruments of healing or harm, connection or division. In the kingdom of God, conversations are never neutral—they are opportunities to reflect the love, truth, and presence of Jesus.

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Here are some functional, practical ways to grow in conversation, using Scripture as our guide:

1. Start With Listening: The Book of Proverbs and the Power of Ears

Too often, we think communication is about having the right words. But biblically, good conversation starts with listening.

“To answer before listening— that is folly and shame”
(Proverbs 18:13).

“Everyone should be quick to listen, slow to speak, and slow to become angry” (James 1:19).

Listening is one of the most practical acts of love. It says, “You matter. Your words matter.” Jesus modeled this constantly. He let people speak. He asked questions. Even when He already knew the answer, He let people process out loud. Listening builds trust.

Practical Step: Try asking more than you tell. When someone shares something, resist the urge to jump in with a solution or story of your own. Instead, ask follow-up questions. Show you’re present.

2. Speak Truth With Grace: Jesus and the Woman at the Well

Jesus never dodged hard conversations. But He also never used truth as a weapon. When He met the Samaritan woman at the well (John 4), He brought up deeply personal, even painful truths—her past relationships, her current living situation. But He didn’t shame her. He spoke with compassion and clarity: offering her living water, not condemnation.

Our conversations will sometimes require truth-telling. But the goal is never to win an argument—it’s to restore, heal, and connect.

“Let your conversation be always full of grace, seasoned with salt...” (Colossians 4:6).

Practical Step: When you need to say something hard, check your tone and intent first. Ask, “Am I saying this to help or to prove a point?” Truth without grace isolates. Grace without truth enables. We need both.

3. Choose Unity Over Being Right: Paul and the Early Church

The early church wasn’t without conflict. In Acts 15, leaders met to settle a major disagreement over Gentile believers and Jewish law. There were strong opinions on both sides. But instead of splintering, they gathered, listened, discussed, and sought the Spirit together. The result? Unity—and a decision that helped the church grow.

Sometimes our conversations break down because we’re more committed to being right than being in relationship. But conversation isn’t a competition—it’s a bridge.

“If it is possible, as far as it depends on you, live at peace with everyone” (Romans 12:18).

Practical Step: In tense moments, ask yourself, “Is what I’m about to say building connection or creating distance?” Unity doesn’t mean we always agree—it means we stay engaged without demeaning each other.

4. Ask Good Questions: Jesus the Master Conversationalist

Jesus rarely gave simple answers. He asked questions that invited reflection, honesty, and personal response. “Who do you say I am?” “Do you want to be well?” “Why are you so afraid?” These weren’t rhetorical—they were invitations to real dialogue.

We grow in connection not just by sharing opinions, but by drawing others out. Good questions show interest. They uncover what’s under the surface.

Practical Step: Shift from small talk to real talk. Instead of “How’s your week?” try “What’s been the hardest part of your week?” Instead of “What’s new?” try “What’s something you’re excited—or anxious—about right now?”

5. Make Space for Silence: Job’s Friends (At First)

When Job’s world fell apart, his friends showed up. And for seven days, they sat in silence with him. No advice. No clichés. Just presence. That was their most helpful act. The problems started when they opened their mouths and tried to explain things they didn’t understand.

Sometimes the best “conversation” is just being with someone in their pain, without trying to fix it.

Practical Step: Don't rush to fill silence. In grief, conflict, or confusion, just being present can be more powerful than the perfect words.

Conclusion: The Way We Speak Shapes the Way We Live

The invitation in this chapter is simple, but powerful: Let your words become a means of grace. Let them reflect the patience, wisdom, and gentleness of Jesus. Don't be afraid to speak truth—but let that truth be spoken with tenderness. And when you don't know what to say, stay present anyway. Silence, too, can be sacred when filled with love.

Because when we speak with the Spirit—and not just from emotion—we become vessels of healing. Our homes change. Our friendships deepen. Our churches flourish. And the God who formed the world with a word continues His creative work through the words we choose every day.

So let's keep talking—with honesty, with humility, and with hope. Because Christ is forming us through every conversation.

Prayer of Consecration for Our Speech

Father, Son, and Holy Spirit—

You are the God who speaks life into being,
Who formed the world with a word,
And who invites us to speak in a way that reflects Your love.

We consecrate our words to You now.

May our mouths become instruments of peace, not division—
Of blessing, not bitterness.

Sanctify our conversations—both the quiet and the public ones—
That they would carry Your wisdom, truth, and grace.

Teach us to listen with compassion,
To speak with kindness,
To challenge with humility,
And to comfort with sincerity.

Forgive us for the careless ways we've used our tongues—
To wound, to protect ourselves, to manipulate, or to retreat.
Redeem those places.

Heal what has been broken by harsh words or prolonged silence.
And help us build new rhythms of trust and love.

Jesus, You are the Word made flesh.

Let our words be marked by Your Spirit—
Full of mercy, full of light, full of courage.

Holy Spirit, fill our mouths with truth and our hearts with gentleness.

When we don't know what to say, teach us to wait on You.

And when we speak, may our words carry Your presence.

Make our conversations sacred.

Let them be a living witness of the Gospel—

Not just in what we say, but in how we say it.

We give You our voices.

Use them for Your glory.

In Jesus' name,

Amen.

Chapter 10: Conversations Across Cultures *by Hazen*

In our increasingly diverse world, the ability to have meaningful conversations across cultural differences is not just helpful—it's essential. The United States is rapidly approaching a demographic watershed moment: according to U.S. Census Bureau projections, by 2045 the nation will become "majority-minority," with whites comprising less than 50% of the total population (Brookings Institution, 2022). Already, among youth under 18, the combined minorities outnumber whites. This dramatic shift means that for the Church to effectively fulfill its mission and share the gospel with our changing society, we must develop the skills needed to build bridges across cultural differences.

These demographic changes present both a challenge and an opportunity for the American Church. While the percentage of multiracial congregations has nearly tripled over the past two decades, with approximately a quarter of evangelical and Catholic churches now being multiracial (Baylor University, 2020), the vast majority of congregations remain culturally homogeneous. This reality stands in stark contrast to the increasingly diverse

communities we are called to serve and to the biblical vision of the Church as a reconciled community that transcends cultural boundaries.

The call to navigate cultural differences isn't about following trendy social initiatives or corporate diversity programs—it's about faithfulness to the gospel itself. As the Apostle Paul reminded the Ephesians, Christ "has made the two groups one and has destroyed the barrier, the dividing wall of hostility" (Ephesians 2:14). Jesus himself prayed for his followers to experience a unity that would testify to the world about His identity (John 17:21). Our ability to have meaningful conversations across cultural lines directly impacts our effectiveness in representing Christ in a divided world.

As I wrote in "Know Own Change," *"Building real relationships is messy work. We must not settle for a form of reconciliation that assuages the conscience with the appearance of unity but avoids the hard work of building enduring relationships."* This insight came from years of working in racial reconciliation and witnessing how easily we can substitute superficial interaction for genuine understanding.

The Four Pillars of Cross-Cultural Conversation

Through my work with OneRace Movement and co-authoring "Know Own Change" with Josh Clemons, I've discovered four essential elements that create the foundation for healthy cross-cultural dialogue:

1. Self-Reflection:

Before engaging in cross-cultural conversations, take time to examine your own cultural lens and biases. This inner work is foundational to authentic cross-cultural engagement.

My journey began with a painful realization: I had spent most of my life assuming my perspective was "normal" while seeing others' cultural expressions as departures from that norm. Growing up in a predominantly white environment, I had unconsciously absorbed the idea that my worship style, communication patterns, and theological emphases were the default setting for Christianity. This unconscious centering of my experience created blind spots that limited my ability to truly hear brothers and sisters from different backgrounds.

Self-reflection requires asking uncomfortable questions: What cultural values shape my communication style? What assumptions might I be making about "normal" conversation? How might my

position of privilege or experience of marginalization affect this interaction? The answers often reveal how deeply culture has shaped our sense of "right" and "wrong" ways to communicate.

For me, this meant recognizing how my white, Western background valued direct communication, emotional restraint, and linear thinking. When I encountered African American expressions of faith that emphasized narrative, emotional expressiveness, and communal processing, I initially felt uncomfortable—not because these approaches were wrong, but because they differed from my cultural experience.

This self-reflection isn't about inducing guilt or engaging in political identity politics—it's about honest assessment of how our cultural context shapes our perspective. Just as Paul became "all things to all people" (1 Corinthians 9:22) to effectively share the gospel, we too must understand how our cultural background influences our approach to ministry and relationship.

Self-reflection doesn't happen once; it's an ongoing process. Even after years of cross-cultural ministry, I regularly discover new biases and assumptions. Each discovery is an opportunity for growth, not a reason for shame. This self-awareness creates the humility needed to step outside our cultural "bubbles" and truly hear others, recognizing that our way of seeing the world is just one perspective among many.

2. Trust-Building:

Cross-cultural conversations require mutual trust that must be intentionally developed. Without trust, even the most carefully chosen words will fall on suspicious ears. Trust cannot be manufactured or rushed; it must be cultivated through consistent actions over time.

I've found that building trust across cultural lines requires several key elements. First is demonstrating consistent reliability in your words and actions. When you say you'll do something, do it—especially when it's difficult or inconvenient. This reliability communicates that you can be counted on regardless of cultural differences.

Second is showing appropriate vulnerability about your own journey. In my early days with OneRace Movement, I discovered that acknowledging my own cultural blind spots and sharing my struggles to understand different perspectives created space for others to be authentic as well. Vulnerability signals that you're not positioning yourself as the expert on someone else's experience, but as a fellow learner on the journey toward understanding.

Third is creating healthy spaces where difficult topics can be discussed honestly. This means establishing ground rules for conversation that honor everyone's dignity and establishing that

questions asked in good faith are welcome. In our reconciliation work, we often began gatherings by explicitly stating things like, "This is a grace-filled space where we can make mistakes as we learn together." This permission to be imperfect removed some of the fear that paralyzes cross-cultural conversation.

Finally, building trust means following through on commitments, especially when they're uncomfortable. Early in my reconciliation work, I promised my African American brothers and sisters that I would consistently speak out against racial injustice, even in predominantly white spaces where such messages might not be warmly received. Over the years, I've faithfully honored this commitment—sometimes at significant personal cost. There have been moments when I've lost speaking opportunities, strained relationships, or been misunderstood by white colleagues who questioned my "focus" on these issues. But each time I've chosen to speak difficult truths despite the consequences, it has deepened trust with my brothers and sisters of color. They've seen that my commitment to reconciliation isn't contingent on convenience or comfort. This consistent follow-through has done more to build genuine cross-cultural relationships than a hundred comfortable conversations ever could.

3. Proximity:

Meaningful cross-cultural conversations rarely happen in isolation. They flourish through intentional proximity—regularly placing ourselves in environments where we are not the cultural majority.

My understanding of this principle crystallized during the early days of OneRace Movement. I could read books about racial reconciliation and attend conferences on multi-ethnic churches, but nothing transformed me like consistent presence in spaces where I was the cultural minority. Attending predominantly African American worship services, being the only white person at community gatherings, sitting at tables where I was the one who needed to adapt—these experiences reshaped my understanding in ways intellectual knowledge never could.

Proximity involves sharing meals, celebrations, and everyday moments across cultural lines. There's something about breaking bread together that breaks down barriers. Some of our most significant breakthroughs in racial reconciliation came not during formal meetings but around dinner tables, at birthday celebrations, or during long car rides between events. These "ordinary" moments often create space for extraordinary honesty.

This approach mirrors what we see throughout the New Testament. Jesus didn't just preach about loving Samaritans—he traveled

through Samaria and engaged with its people. The early church didn't just discuss Jewish-Gentile reconciliation in abstract terms—they created communities where both groups lived, worshipped, and served together despite profound cultural differences. Proximity wasn't a secondary strategy; it was central to how the gospel broke down dividing walls of hostility.

Experiencing the lived realities of others firsthand is irreplaceable. I remember hearing the experiences of my black colleagues who had been routinely on the receiving end of police harassment. Having only experienced respectful treatment from law enforcement, I might have intellectually acknowledged their stories but privately doubted their prevalence— except that I continued to hear the same stories over and over. Proximity transformed an intellectual understanding into visceral knowledge as I experienced these stories from people I loved and trusted and not just news or social media.

Perhaps most importantly, proximity requires entering spaces as a learner rather than an expert. Too often, I've seen well-meaning people enter cross-cultural situations ready to "help" or "fix" without first understanding the context. True proximity means coming with humble curiosity, acknowledging that those who live within a culture understand it better than those observing from outside.

One of the most transformative experiences in my reconciliation journey was organizing the OneRace Stone Mountain gathering in

2018, where over 20,000 believers from diverse backgrounds came together in a place historically associated with racism. Standing shoulder to shoulder with brothers and sisters from different ethnic backgrounds at that historic site—praying, worshipping, and lamenting together—changed me in ways theoretical knowledge never could. That day exemplified the truth that proximity creates both discomfort and opportunity for genuine relationships. We were changed by being together with God, reclaiming a place of historic wickedness for God's redemptive purpose.

4. Intentionality Over Time:

Cross-cultural understanding doesn't happen overnight. It requires sustained commitment through both breakthroughs and setbacks.

In our microwave culture, we often expect instant results. But reconciliation work has taught me that meaningful cross-cultural relationships develop at the speed of trust—and trust takes time. The most significant relationships across cultural lines in my life have been developed over years, not days or weeks.

This intentionality means committing to relationships for the long haul, even through misunderstandings. I remember a painful conversation with an African American pastor early in our friendship. I had made a comment that unintentionally minimized the reality of ongoing racism, and he called me on it directly. My

initial impulse was defensiveness, followed by the temptation to withdraw from the relationship to avoid further discomfort. But we both chose to stay engaged, working through the tension rather than abandoning the connection.

Being willing to circle back to difficult conversations is another aspect of intentionality. Cross-cultural relationships often include moments when we hit conversational walls or trigger unintended pain. In these moments, it's tempting to simply move on to safer topics. But an authentic relationship requires the courage to return to difficult subjects with a fresh perspective. Some of our most significant breakthroughs in OneRace came when we revisited conversations that had previously ended in frustration. Investing consistent time and energy in cross-cultural relationships signals that people are a priority, not a project.

Finally, intentionality involves celebrating small wins while maintaining patience for deeper change. Reconciliation work rarely produces dramatic transformations that make for exciting testimonies. Instead, it happens through countless small moments of increased understanding, growing trust, and subtle shifts in perspective. Learning to celebrate these incremental changes—a formerly guarded person sharing more openly, a defensive reaction replaced by curious questions—sustains the work when large-scale change seems distant.

The journey of cross-cultural relationships isn't linear. It involves steps forward and backward, moments of profound connection and painful disconnection. Intentionality means committing to the whole journey, not just the mountaintop experiences.

Cultural Humility in Practice

Cultural humility transforms our approach to conversation. Unlike cultural competence, which suggests mastery, cultural humility acknowledges that we are always learning. In "Know Own Change," we emphasized that cultural humility "means we recognize that we have a culture and that this culture, particularly for people coming from the majority culture, impacts others. Our culture is not at the center of the universe; the culture of the kingdom is."

This shift from cultural competence to cultural humility marked a turning point in my reconciliation work. Cultural competence implied that with enough knowledge, I could become an "expert" on other cultures. Cultural humility, by contrast, positioned me as a perpetual learner, recognizing that cultures are complex, ever-evolving realities that cannot be mastered through reading books or attending workshops.

Cultural humility begins with the recognition that every person is shaped by culture, not just those from minority groups. As a white

American, I had often thought of myself as "just normal" while seeing others as having "culture." This unconscious centering of my experience made it difficult to recognize how deeply my communication patterns, conflict styles, worship preferences, and theological emphases were shaped by my specific cultural background.

This perspective isn't derived from secular ideologies but from biblical principles. When Paul talked about becoming "all things to all people" (1 Corinthians 9:22), he wasn't suggesting superficial cultural tourism but a deep understanding of how culture shapes communication and relationships. His ability to move between Jewish and Gentile contexts demonstrated cultural humility—recognizing that his own cultural perspective, while valid, wasn't universal or superior.

Embracing cultural humility means acknowledging that our way of seeing and being in the world is just one among many. It approaches difference with curiosity rather than judgment and values the wisdom embedded in diverse cultural perspectives. Perhaps most importantly, it recognizes that we never "arrive" at complete cultural understanding but remain on a lifelong journey of learning and growth.

The following practices help cultivate cultural humility in our conversations.

Listen More Than You Speak: In cross-cultural settings, practice the 70/30 rule—listen 70% of the time and speak 30%. This creates space for understanding before being understood.

This principle challenged me deeply when I first encountered it. As someone comfortable with public speaking and passionate about reconciliation, my natural inclination was to talk more than listen. I believed that if I could just articulate my thoughts clearly enough, understanding would follow. But cross-cultural contexts revealed the limitations of this approach.

In a pivotal conversation with an African American friend, I noticed him growing increasingly quiet as I enthusiastically shared my ideas about multicultural ministry. When I finally paused and asked what he was thinking, he gently said, "In my culture, we listen to understand before we speak. I'm still trying to understand you, but you seem more interested in being understood." His observation stung because it was true. I had been dominating the conversation, leaving little room for his perspective.

Learning to listen doesn't mean remaining silent; it means asking thoughtful questions and then truly attending to the answers rather than mentally preparing your next point. It means noticing not just words but tone, body language, and what remains unsaid. It means resisting the urge to immediately respond to everything you hear.

When I deliberately practiced the 70/30 rule in subsequent conversations, I discovered something surprising: the less I spoke, the more influence I actually had. My fewer words carried more weight because they were informed by genuine understanding rather than assumptions. And people became more interested in my perspective once they felt deeply heard themselves.

The 70/30 principle applies not just to individual conversations but to group settings as well. In multicultural gatherings, those from dominant cultures often unconsciously take up disproportionate space. Being mindful of this pattern and intentionally creating room for diverse voices enriches everyone's experience.

Ask Questions Instead of Making Assumptions: Rather than presuming you understand another's perspective, ask clarifying questions that invite deeper sharing.

Early in my reconciliation journey, I often approached conversations with unconscious assumptions about others' experiences. When an African American colleague mentioned feeling uncomfortable in certain spaces, I would immediately think I understood why, based on what I'd read about racism. But when I began asking genuine questions—"Can you help me understand what that experience is like for you?"—I discovered that my assumptions were frequently incomplete or entirely wrong.

Effective cross-cultural questions acknowledge the limits of our perspective while inviting others to share theirs: "How might your cultural background shape how you see this situation?" or "What am I missing from my perspective that might be important here?" These questions signal humility and genuine interest rather than presumed expertise.

The art of asking good questions requires careful attention to both content and delivery. Questions that begin with "why" can sometimes feel confrontational or demanding justification. Questions prefaced with "I'm curious about..." or "Would you be willing to help me understand..." often create safer space for honest response.

I've learned to pay attention to whether my questions arise from genuine curiosity or from a desire to prove a point or reinforce my existing perspective. Genuine questions remain open to unexpected answers, while agenda-driven questions often reveal themselves through how quickly we argue with responses that don't match our expectations.

Perhaps most importantly, asking questions requires accepting that some may go unanswered. People from marginalized groups often bear the burden of educating others about their experience. Respecting someone's choice not to answer certain questions demonstrates awareness of this reality. When someone does choose

to share their perspective in response to a question, receiving it as a gift rather than an entitlement builds trust for future conversation.

Acknowledge Power Dynamics: Every conversation has underlying power dynamics related to majority/minority status, historical privilege/oppression, and positional authority. Naming these dynamics openly can create more honest dialogue.

Power dynamics are always present in cross-cultural conversations, whether acknowledged or not. Ignoring these realities doesn't make them disappear; it simply pushes them beneath the surface where they continue to shape interaction in unexamined ways. I've found that gently naming these dynamics—"I realize as a [majority culture member], my experience differs from yours"—can create space for more authentic exchange.

Understanding power dynamics requires recognizing both personal and historical contexts. When I sit across from someone whose cultural group has historically been marginalized or even harmed by my cultural group, pretending we're having a conversation in which that history doesn't exist ignores significant realities that shape how we each experience the interaction. This doesn't mean that history needs to dominate our thinking either, it just needs to be kept in our awareness. Acknowledging this context doesn't mean being paralyzed by guilt or shame over history's inequities; it means bringing awareness to factors that influence communication.

I learned this lesson personally during the founding of OneRace Movement. In one pivotal conversation, an African American pastor pointed his finger at me and asked, "When this racial reconciliation work gets hard and messy, you will have the luxury of walking away. But he won't..." speaking of a black colleague at the table. He elaborated, "Because what is a choice for you is what we live with daily. So what are you going to do when the work gets hard?" His question cut to the heart of power dynamics—as a white man, I could choose to engage or disengage from conversations about race, while my brothers and sisters of color couldn't simply opt out of their lived experience.

That confrontation helped me understand something essential: acknowledging power differences isn't about shame or placing blame. It's about truthfulness. When I name the reality that I can choose when to engage with racial issues while others cannot as easily, I'm not diminishing myself but simply acknowledging a reality that shapes our different perspectives. This truthfulness builds trust in ways that pretended equality never could.

Historical contexts also matter in understanding power dynamics. When discussing issues where significant historical injustice has occurred, statements like "I want to acknowledge the historical context that might affect how we discuss this" can help create space for addressing not just present realities but their historical roots.

This approach invites all participants to consider how history shapes our present moment without assuming everyone sees that history the same way.

Embrace Productive Discomfort: Cross-cultural conversations will inevitably involve moments of tension, awkwardness, or discomfort. Rather than avoiding these moments, see them as doorways to deeper understanding.

One of the most significant barriers to cross-cultural connection is our natural aversion to discomfort. We're wired to seek ease and avoid tension. Yet my experience in reconciliation work has convinced me that the most transformative conversations almost always include periods of discomfort. The question isn't whether discomfort will arise, but how we respond when it does.

Staying engaged when conversations become challenging requires recognizing our fight-or-flight responses. When a conversation touches on sensitive cultural issues, I've noticed my own tendency to either become defensive (fight) or change the subject (flight). Learning to recognize these responses in my body—tightness in my chest, accelerated heartbeat, the impulse to interrupt—has helped me develop the capacity to stay present even when uncomfortable.

Recognizing emotional responses without being controlled by them is essential for productive cross-cultural dialogue. In a tense

conversation about equality in hiring, I found myself feeling deeply misunderstood and unfairly judged. Rather than reacting from that emotion, I was able to name it internally: "I'm feeling defensive right now, and that's making it hard for me to listen well." This awareness created space between my feelings and my response, allowing me to stay engaged rather than shutting down or lashing out.

Perhaps most importantly, embracing productive discomfort means viewing misunderstandings as opportunities for growth, not failures to be avoided. Early in my reconciliation work, I dreaded making cultural mistakes and would become discouraged when misunderstandings occurred. Over time, I've come to see these moments not as failures but as invitations to deeper understanding.

I remember a conversation where I unintentionally had done something that an African American colleague found diminishing and dismissive of him. He courageously addressed it with me, and in the uncomfortable silence that followed, I had a choice: defend my intentions, change the subject, or lean into the discomfort by asking for help understanding the impact of my actions. Choosing the third option led to one of our most honest conversations and strengthened rather than damaged our relationship.

The willingness to stay engaged through discomfort signals that the relationship matters more than personal comfort. This doesn't mean accepting abuse or remaining in truly harmful situations. Rather, it

means recognizing that growth and transformation rarely happen in zones of perfect comfort.

Repair When Needed: Even with the best intentions, we will make mistakes in cross-cultural conversations. When this happens, the path to restored relationship runs through genuine repair.

Making mistakes across cultural lines is not a possibility but an inevitability. No matter how culturally aware we become, we will occasionally speak or act in ways that cause harm or create distance. What determines the future of the relationship isn't the absence of mistakes but how we respond when they occur.

Apologizing specifically without defensiveness is the first step in meaningful repair. General apologies like "I'm sorry if anyone was offended" subtly shift responsibility to others' sensitivity rather than our actions. Specific apologies—"I'm sorry for interrupting you repeatedly during our conversation"—acknowledge exactly what went wrong and take full responsibility.

Early in my reconciliation work, I made a comment during a multiethnic gathering that unintentionally reinforced harmful stereotypes about Black communities. When this was pointed out to me, my immediate impulse was to explain what I "really meant" and why people shouldn't have taken offense. Fortunately, a mentor had advised me that when you step on someone's foot, you don't explain

that you didn't mean to or that they shouldn't feel pain—you simply apologize and then listen to understand the impact of your actions.

Listening to the impact of your words or actions without justification is the second essential element of repair. This means creating space for others to express how they experienced your words or actions without jumping in to defend your intentions. One of the hardest lessons I've learned is that impact matters more than intent in repairing relationships. Good intentions don't erase harmful impacts.

In my journey, I've made my share of mistakes—saying the wrong thing, making assumptions, or failing to recognize how my words might impact someone from a different background. What I've learned is that how we respond to these mistakes often matters more than the mistakes themselves. When I've humbled myself, truly listened to feedback without becoming defensive, and demonstrated genuine change, relationships have often deepened rather than fractured.

Changing your behavior based on what you've learned demonstrates that the apology was more than words. When someone takes the risk of pointing out a mistake or harmful pattern, they're often watching to see whether this vulnerability leads to actual change. Nothing builds trust more powerfully than seeing someone accept feedback and then adjust their behavior accordingly. Conversely, nothing

erodes trust faster than repeated apologies followed by the same harmful actions.

Finally, continuing the relationship with new understanding is the ultimate goal of repair. This means not allowing shame about past mistakes to prevent future engagement. The willingness to repair shows that we value the relationship more than our own comfort or ego. It transforms mistakes from relationship-ending failures into opportunities for deeper connection based on humility and growth.

The Spiritual Foundation of Cross-Cultural Conversation

As believers, our ability to navigate cultural differences in conversation is not merely a social skill or corporate diversity initiative but a spiritual discipline deeply rooted in the gospel. The ministry of reconciliation—both between God and people, and between people across dividing walls—lies at the very heart of our calling as Christians. In 2 Corinthians 5:18, Paul writes that God "reconciled us to himself through Christ and gave us the ministry of reconciliation." This ministry encompasses not just spiritual reconciliation but the breaking down of "dividing walls of hostility" (Ephesians 2:14) between different peoples.

The early church faced one of history's deepest cultural and racial divides—between Jews and Gentiles. This wasn't simply a matter of different customs or languages; it was an identity-defining separation reinforced by centuries of religious practice, historical conflict, and mutual suspicion. Yet the revolutionary message of the New Testament was that Christ had made "the two groups one" (Ephesians 2:14). This reconciliation wasn't just theological theory but was lived out in newly formed communities where Jews and Gentiles ate together, worshiped together, and served together despite their profound differences.

In "Know Own Change," we explored how Jesus consistently crossed cultural boundaries. When Jesus encountered the Samaritan woman at the well, he broke multiple cultural taboos—a Jewish man speaking to a Samaritan woman—not as a cultural tourist, but as someone genuinely invested in her well-being. He modeled for us that true connection comes through humility and genuine concern rather than curiosity or obligation.

Paul reminds us in Philippians 2:3-5: "Do nothing from selfish ambition or conceit, but in humility count others more significant than yourselves. Let each of you look not only to his own interests, but also to the interests of others. Have this mind among yourselves, which is yours in Christ Jesus."

This Christ-like mindset is the foundation of all meaningful cross-cultural conversation. When we approach others with the humble recognition that every person bears God's image and has a story worth hearing, we create space for authentic dialogue that honors both our unity in Christ and our beautiful diversity as His creation.

Through my work with OneRace Movement, I've become deeply convinced that the Church should lead rather than lag in the work of reconciliation across cultural divides. We have both the theological foundation and the historical model for this work. The same gospel that reconciled ancient enemies can reconcile modern ones. While society often approaches diversity through political frameworks or corporate initiatives, we have something far more powerful—a tested model of reconciliation through Christ that has been breaking down barriers for two thousand years.

When the Church demonstrates healthy cross-cultural relationships, we offer the world a powerful witness to the reconciling power of the gospel. We show that the kingdom of God is not just a future hope but a present reality where "there is neither Jew nor Greek, slave nor free, male nor female, for you are all one in Christ Jesus" (Galatians 3:28). This witness becomes especially powerful in a fractured world hungry for genuine connection across lines of difference.

When my friends and I began the work that would become OneRace Movement, we didn't start with strategies or events. We started with meals—sharing tables, stories, and eventually our lives. These intentional conversations across cultural lines built the trust necessary to later mobilize thousands. Through this experience, I've learned that reconciliation isn't primarily achieved through programs or proclamations, but through persistent, humble presence with one another. The intimacy of conversation—real, honest, sometimes difficult conversation—is where the work of reconciliation takes root.

As you engage across cultural differences, remember that the goal isn't perfect understanding or saying all the right things. The goal is to create space where the image of God in both you and the other person can be more fully seen, honored, and celebrated. This sacred work of conversation across differences isn't peripheral to our faith—it's central to becoming more like Christ.

Jesus at the Well: Embodying Cross-Cultural Conversation

As the Judean sun climbed higher in the sky, Jesus rested beside Jacob's well in Samaria. Weary from his journey, he waited as his disciples went to find food. In this moment of apparent

ordinariness, something extraordinary was about to unfold—a conversation that would cross boundaries of ethnicity, gender, religion, and social status. His encounter with the Samaritan woman offers us not just a story to admire but a living demonstration of the cross-cultural principles we've explored throughout this chapter.

Picture the scene: a Jewish rabbi sitting alone at a well in Samaritan territory. The cultural animosity between these groups stretched back centuries—a tension so palpable that most Jews would travel miles out of their way to avoid setting foot on Samaritan soil. Yet here sat Jesus, not just passing through but intentionally creating space for encounter. Before a word was spoken, his very presence demonstrated the power of proximity we discussed earlier. Jesus didn't theorize about Samaritans from a safe distance; he entered their world, experiencing their context firsthand.

When the woman approached to draw water, Jesus began with a simple request: "Will you give me a drink?" In this humble opening, we see the fruit of self-reflection. Though fully aware of the cultural scripts that should have prevented this interaction, Jesus chose not to be limited by them. His cultural awareness gave him freedom rather than constraints. He recognized the boundary without being bound by it. In our cross-cultural conversations today, this same self-awareness allows us to acknowledge cultural differences while seeing beyond them to our shared humanity.

Notice the gentleness with which Jesus built trust across this formidable cultural divide. He began not with demands or pronouncements but with vulnerability—expressing his own need for water. This created immediate mutuality in the exchange. Though he was a rabbi with cultural privilege, he positioned himself as a fellow human with basic needs. The woman's surprise is evident in her response: "How is it that you, a Jew, ask for a drink from me, a woman of Samaria?" Her question acknowledges the cultural impossibility of this interaction, yet Jesus created a space safe enough for her to engage rather than retreat.

As their conversation unfolded under the midday sun, Jesus demonstrated the art of cultural humility. Though possessing divine knowledge, he didn't dominate the exchange. He listened attentively to her perspectives on worship traditions and messianic expectations. When she expressed her understanding that "when Messiah comes, he will tell us all things," Jesus honored her insight. He gave her space to voice her thoughts, practicing what we might call the sacred dance of conversation—speaking and listening in a rhythm that honors both voices.

The dialogue winds along unexpected paths, touching on her marital history, theological disputes about proper worship locations, and ultimately the nature of true spiritual connection. Through each turn, Jesus remained engaged even when the conversation

entered uncomfortable territory. Rather than avoiding tension, he used it productively to create transformation. This mirrors our principle of embracing productive discomfort—staying present through the challenging moments that often arise in cross-cultural exchange.

When misunderstanding occurred—as when the woman initially thought Jesus was speaking of physical rather than spiritual water—he responded with patience and clarity rather than frustration. "Everyone who drinks this water will be thirsty again," he explained, creating a bridge from her understanding to deeper revelation. This demonstrates how we can navigate the inevitable moments of confusion in cross-cultural settings, seeing them not as failures but as opportunities for greater clarity and connection.

Perhaps most powerfully, Jesus asked questions that invited her participation rather than making assumptions about her. "Go call your husband and come back," he suggested, creating an opening for her to share her reality rather than pronouncing judgment. Even with supernatural knowledge of her situation, he engaged her as an active participant in the conversation, not a passive recipient of his wisdom. This approach echoes our emphasis on asking genuine questions rather than projecting our assumptions onto others from different cultural backgrounds.

What began as a one-to-one conversation beside a well expanded to impact an entire community. The woman who came alone at midday—possibly to avoid the judgment of her neighbors—returned to those same neighbors as an evangelist. "Come see a man who told me everything I ever did," she announced, no longer hiding but boldly sharing her encounter. The transformation in her life rippled outward, leading many Samaritans to invite Jesus to stay with them.

Here we see the principle of intentionality over time. Jesus didn't rush away after one successful cross-cultural exchange but accepted their invitation to stay for two days. This extended engagement allowed relationships to deepen beyond initial curiosity. Many more Samaritans came to faith, telling the woman, "We no longer believe just because of what you said; now we have heard for ourselves." What began with one conversation grew into community transformation because Jesus was willing to invest time, not just technique.

The well where this encounter took place had deep significance. Centuries earlier, Jacob had dug this well to provide water for his family in a foreign land. Now at this same location, living water was flowing again across boundaries of hostility. Wells in ancient times were places of meeting, negotiation, and sometimes conflict resolution. In choosing this location for cross-cultural engagement,

Jesus honored a tradition of boundary-crossing that stretched back to the patriarchs.

As the Samaritan sun set on Jesus' two-day stay, something profound had shifted. A community previously defined by separation had experienced connection. A woman previously defined by her past had stepped into a new future. Ancient hostilities had given way, even momentarily, to newfound faith. All this flowed from a conversation that honored cultural differences while seeing beyond them to deeper truth.

The power of this encounter wasn't ultimately in technique but in Jesus' heart posture. He saw beyond cultural categories to the image of God in this woman. He recognized her thirst—not just for water but for truth, acceptance, and the living water that would satisfy her deepest needs. He approached her not as a project but as a person worthy of dignity and capable of spiritual insight.

As we practice cross-cultural conversation in our own contexts—across conference tables or coffee tables, in boardrooms or living rooms—may we carry this same heart. When we approach cultural differences with self-awareness, intentionality, humility, and love, we participate in Jesus' ongoing reconciling work in the world.

Each cross-cultural conversation becomes a sacred opportunity—a place where, like Jacob's well, heaven and earth meet, ancient

boundaries dissolve, and living water flows freely between hearts long separated by walls of misunderstanding. In these holy exchanges, we don't just talk about the kingdom; we experience it breaking through in our midst.

Chapter 11: Conversations with Non-Christians About God *by Hazen*

We are called to share our faith—but let’s be honest: talking about God with others can feel intimidating. It’s not always simple, clear, or comfortable. We wonder: What if they push back? What if I don’t know enough? What if I come across as preachy or awkward?

But here’s the deeper truth: when our faith is truly alive, it naturally shows up in our everyday conversations. Not as a rehearsed speech or a sales pitch, but as a lived reality—something authentic, relational, and filled with hope.

“Always be prepared to give an answer to everyone who asks you to give the reason for the hope that you have. But do this with gentleness and respect...”
(1 Peter 3:15).

This chapter is about learning how to do that—to speak about God in a way that is clear but humble, bold but gentle. Whether we’re speaking to fellow believers, honest seekers, or skeptical friends, our aim is not to win arguments—it’s to open hearts. Because often, the

most life-changing evangelism doesn't come through a pulpit. It starts with a conversation.

Why These Conversations Matter

God communicates through words. He spoke creation into being. Jesus is called the Word made flesh. And the early church was a community of conversation—not just proclamation.

- Philip dialogued with the Ethiopian eunuch (Acts 8).
- Paul reasoned with people in synagogues and marketplaces (Acts 17).
- Jesus asked over 300 questions in the Gospels—not to trap, but to invite people into deeper thought and reflection.

Faith spreads through relationship and dialogue. Real transformation often begins not with a sermon but with a thoughtful exchange between two people. These moments matter.

The Simplicity of Sharing our Lived Stories

In 1 Peter 2:9, believers are described as "a chosen people, a royal priesthood, a holy nation, God's special possession," called to "declare the praises of Him who called you out of darkness into His wonderful light." This passage underscores that sharing our faith

doesn't necessitate intricate theology or persuasive arguments; rather, it can be as simple as recounting our personal experiences of God's work in our lives. Psalm 66:16 echoes this sentiment: "Come and hear, all you who fear God; let me tell you what he has done for me." By sharing our stories of transformation and grace, we fulfill our role in proclaiming God's excellencies, offering others a tangible testament to His love and power.

The Gospel of John presents the story of a man blind from birth who receives sight through Jesus' miraculous intervention. When interrogated by the Pharisees about his healing, the man simply states, "One thing I do know: I was blind, and now I can see!" (John 9:25, Christian Standard Bible). He doesn't engage in theological debates about Jesus' nature; instead, he shares his personal experience. This candid testimony highlights that sharing about God can be as straightforward as recounting what He has done in our lives. Our personal stories of transformation and grace serve as powerful proclamations of God's work, inviting others to witness His goodness through our lived experiences.

The apostle John emphasizes the tangible reality of Jesus Christ in 1 John 1:1, stating, "That which was from the beginning, which we have heard, which we have seen with our eyes, which we have looked at and our hands have touched—this we proclaim concerning the Word of life." This underscores that sharing our faith is rooted in personal encounters and experiences with Christ. Just as John and

the other apostles shared what they had personally witnessed and experienced, we too are called to share the impact of Jesus in our lives. Our testimonies, drawn from our own experiences of His grace and truth, serve as compelling witnesses to others.

The Three Core Postures of a Faithful Conversation

When we speak about God, our tone and posture matter as much as our words. The fruit of the Spirit should be as present in our tone as in our theology. Here are three essential postures to carry into any conversation:

1. Humility

You're not the Holy Spirit. You don't need to have all the answers. And you're not responsible for someone else's salvation. You're a witness. Your role is to speak honestly, listen attentively, and reflect Christ in how you speak.

“Knowledge puffs up, but love builds up”
(1 Corinthians 8:1, CSB).

Practice: When you don't know something, say so. It builds credibility to admit, “That's a good question—I've wondered about that too.” People trust humility far more than certainty.

2. Truth

Truth matters. Love without truth is hollow. Our message isn't just one of comfort—it's one of transformation. We speak of Jesus, sin, grace, forgiveness, and eternity.

But truth isn't a weapon—it's a way. It can be shared through story, through testimony, and through the sincerity of a changed life.

Practice: Don't shy away from the heart of the Gospel. Share how Jesus has changed you. Let your testimony make the truth real.

3. Love

No one listens to someone who doesn't care. Love means seeing the person, not just the debate. It means listening more than talking. Being patient. And remembering that the person in front of you is deeply loved by God.

Jesus modeled this with everyone He encountered—from Pharisees to tax collectors. He could be direct, but He was always moved by compassion.

Practice: Ask yourself, "Am I trying to connect—or just be right?" Let love lead the way.

With Seekers: Creating Safe Space for Curiosity

Not everyone is resistant. Some people are just unsure. Curious. Exploring. These conversations are often the most fruitful—if we can create an environment where people feel safe to ask questions.

Don't treat them like a project. Treat them like a person.

Tips:

- Ask, “What’s your story when it comes to faith?”
- Share a personal example of how your faith helps you navigate life.
- Focus less on being persuasive, more on being present.

With Skeptics: Engaging with Respect

Some people carry wounds from religion. Others have real intellectual or moral objections. And some just enjoy debate. That’s okay.

You don’t have to argue. You just have to stay calm, curious, and respectful. Often the real issue isn’t theological—it’s personal.

Tips:

- Ask, “What’s been your experience with church or faith?”
- Look for the deeper story beneath the question.

- If things get heated, it's okay to pause: "Thanks for sharing—can I think about that more and circle back?"

Practical Conversation Starters

Here are some non-threatening, thought-provoking questions that can open the door to spiritual conversations:

- "What brings you peace when life is hard?"
- "Do you think there's something bigger than us?"
- "Has anyone ever shared who Jesus really is?"
- "If you could ask God one question, what would it be?"
- "What do you think happens after we die?"

These aren't tricks. They're invitations. They say: I care about what you believe. I'm listening. I'm open.

(See *Appendix: Conversation Toolkit* for how to spark meaningful conversations with unbelievers.)

Earning the Right to Be Heard

I remember speaking to a young woman on a local college campus. She was of Iranian descent and had immigrated with her family to the Northeast. She had never had the opportunity to attend church

before, but as we dialogued about her experiences with faith, I got to listen to her spiritual journey up to that point.

Effective listening shows people we care and opens hearts to listen when our time to speak comes. In this way, by listening, we earn their trust so we can be heard. As a business school student, I remember being coached by career counselors that in an effective interview, we don't want to be the only ones talking—we want the interviewer to talk, even though we're the ones being "considered for the position."

Research confirms this wisdom: A study in the *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology* found that people consistently overestimate how much others want to hear them talk, while underestimating how much others want to speak themselves. The researchers discovered that conversations where both parties share approximately equally are rated as significantly more enjoyable and lead to stronger connection than one-sided exchanges (Quinn & Schroeder, 2021).

Yet as Christians, we often feel the need to preach at people and unload all the right steps in the latest evangelistic method. Don't get me wrong—we need to have both skill and heart. Without skill in communication, we are ineffective, but when we are skilled without a genuine love for others, we're just manipulating.

After hearing her story, I simply asked if she had "ever heard the Gospel message, and that it was the core message of the Christian faith." Think sincerely: if a loved one were suddenly thrown into a situation where their mortality came to the forefront, and because they knew you to be a godly example, they called you having just escaped an intense car accident or received a troubling medical diagnosis—with the question, "What comes next if I were to die? Is heaven real? If it is, how do I get there?"—would you know how to articulate the answer found in Scripture?

When I asked this young woman if she knew the Gospel message, she said no—so I simply asked if I could share it. I felt the Spirit's presence as I explained something she had never heard before. There was a man born in a Jewish town called Nazareth, born of a virgin as a sign of his divinity, but lived as a human, was tempted but did nothing sinful or evil. He helped people—even miraculously healing the sick and performing wonders—and then, because of the jealousy of religious figures, this sinless man was tortured and crucified as a sacrifice for our sin. Lastly, he rose from the dead to show that he was indeed God and has the power to forgive and grant eternal life to those who believe in Him.

As I spoke what naturally sounds like lunacy (in fact, Paul says to the non-Jewish mind this is foolishness), she simply began to break down weeping, completely unsure of why. She kept saying, "I am

sorry, I don't know why I am crying..." But I knew why, because I've seen it happen many times, some of those tears even being my own. The redemptive love story of the Gospel is the story of God's rescue mission for us that every human heart is longing to hear—the whispers of truth that the glory, beauty, and perfection you were created for is possible. The young woman didn't begin to follow Jesus that day, but she did have a unique experience with God, and I committed her life and those Gospel seeds into God's hands. I pray for her now as I write this...

Everyday Opportunities

But not all spiritual conversations are as dramatic, in fact most are mundane. Just this week, while getting subs for our family at a local grocery store for a picnic, the deli worker asked why we were so happy, noticing my family laughing and enjoying ourselves. I simply told him I'm a pastor and that part of why we're joyful is because of our faith. He shared that he was new to following Jesus and still without a church home, so I asked if he and his friend wanted our church's Easter devotional and a copy of my book on how the Gospel changes everything, and of course invited him to check out our Church! My oldest daughter ran to the car to get them from the trunk. This new believer and his friend were so grateful for the simple gift of some resources to strengthen his faith!

I share both examples—one more dramatic, the other more mundane (though who knows how God might use it!)—to illustrate the power of being open and having simple conversations. Matthew 13:2-3, in the story of the seeds and soils, says simply, "A farmer went out to sow seed..." If we approach each day with that mentality, sowing generously (because we have unlimited seed), then each day we will have opportunities to pray for people, hear their stories, share the Gospel, or just give away a book.

When It Doesn't Go Well

Yet, things aren't always as positive as the conversations I shared above. Sometimes the conversation ends abruptly. Someone dismisses you. You feel like you blew it. But remember:

You are not the Savior. You are a seed planter. The Holy Spirit is the one who softens hearts and draws people to Jesus.

"One plants, another waters, but God gives the growth" (1 Corinthians 3:6, ESV).

Even a small moment can echo in someone's life later. Trust that God is at work, even when you can't see it.

Closing Reflection: Keep the Door Open

Talking about God doesn't have to be awkward. It can be natural, honest, and full of grace. You don't need to be perfect—you just need to be present.

Let your life and your words reflect the same story. Speak with truth, humility, and love. Don't try to win people—love them. And let your conversations be doorways to deeper things.

Because what the world needs isn't louder voices—it needs kinder, wiser ones. People who walk closely with Jesus and know how to talk about Him in ways that open hearts instead of closing doors.

Chapter 12: Conversations with God About Others (Intercession) *by Hazen*

Intercessory prayer is a powerful form of spiritual conversation. Lifting others up in prayer aligns our hearts with God’s will and fosters compassion.

This chapter will explore how intercession transforms both the intercessor and the one being prayed for. Using Abraham’s intercession for Sodom and Gomorrah as an example, I will discuss how mature prayer moves beyond self-focused petitions to contending for others.

One of the earliest and clearest pictures of intercession is found in Genesis 18, where Abraham stands before God on behalf of Sodom and Gomorrah. He doesn’t defend the cities—he pleads for the righteous within them. He intercedes with bold compassion.

“Will You sweep away the righteous with the wicked?”
(Genesis 18:23).

Abraham wasn’t praying for himself. He had already been promised a blessing. He was praying for people he didn’t even know—some

righteous, some wicked. What drove him? Compassion. Boldness. A growing awareness of God's justice and mercy.

He starts with fifty. Then asks for forty-five. Then forty. Then thirty, twenty, ten. With every ask, Abraham draws closer to the heart of God. He doesn't pray in fear. He prays in friendship. That's what mature intercession looks like.

And though the cities were ultimately judged, Abraham's prayer teaches us what it means to stand in the gap—not for our comfort, but for the sake of others.

Mature intercession moves us beyond self. It trains us to carry the weight of other people's lives in the presence of God—and to believe that mercy is always worth asking for.

We're not trying to manipulate God. We are trying to align with Him. Real power in prayer starts with knowing what God wants—not just what we want.

Jesus modeled this in Gethsemane:

“Not My will, but Yours be done” (Luke 22:42).

Even in agony, He submitted His desire to the Father's will. That's not passivity—it's spiritual maturity.

1. We discern God's will through:

- Scripture – What has God already spoken?
- The Spirit's prompting – What burden or direction is rising in your spirit?
- Wisdom and counsel – What aligns with the character of God and the context of the situation?

When we pray from discernment, our prayers carry weight because they are rooted in heaven's intention.

Practice: Before interceding, ask: "Father, what do You want here?" Then listen. Wait. Let your desire be shaped by His.

2. Confirm with the Word

Intercession becomes powerful when it is anchored in the promises of God. Scripture is not just a resource—it's our spiritual legal ground. It gives shape, substance, and confidence to our prayers.

"If we ask anything according to His will, He hears us"
(1 John 5:14).

When we pray the Word, we are reminding God (and ourselves) what He has already said. This isn't manipulation—it's agreement.

The Word keeps our intercession from drifting into emotionalism. It gives our passion precision.

Practice: Match each prayer request with a promise. If praying for breakthrough, declare Isaiah 43:19. If praying for peace, speak Philippians 4:6–7. Let your prayers be saturated with truth.

3. Pray with Importunity (Persistence and Boldness)

Intercession is a work of persistence. Jesus taught this through parables (Luke 11, Luke 18)—that we should keep knocking, keep asking, keep pressing.

“Because of your shameless audacity...” (Luke 11:8).

This old word—importunity—means bold, stubborn, unrelenting prayer. It is not passive. It is aggressive in the spirit. Not because God is reluctant—but because persistence reveals desire and builds faith.

This is how Elijah prayed for rain (1 Kings 18:43–44). He didn’t stop after one try. He pressed in seven times until a cloud finally appeared.

Practice: Make space in your life for persistent intercession. Set prayer alarms. Keep a journal. Don’t give up when you feel

resistance. Pray until something shifts—either in the situation or in you.

4. Intercede with Faith and Assurance

We don't intercede with guesswork. We intercede with confidence.

“Let him ask in faith, with no doubting...” (James 1:6, NKJV).

“Believe that you have received it, and it will be yours”
(Mark 11:24).

Intercession is built on trust—that God hears, that God is able, and that God is good. Faith is not wishful thinking—it is anchored conviction.

We may not always see immediate results, but we plant our prayers like seeds. We trust God with the timing and the outcome.

Practice: After you pray, thank God as if it's already done. Declare it: “God, I believe You've heard. I believe You're moving. I will wait with expectation.”

5. Seal It with Praise Until It Manifests

The final movement of intercession is praise. Not because the answer has come—but because God is faithful. Praise turns our focus from the outcome to the One who holds it.

Paul and Silas praised in prison—before the doors opened (Acts 16:25–26). Their praise was the breakthrough.

“In everything by prayer and supplication with thanksgiving...”
(Philippians 4:6, ESV).

Worship sustains us in the waiting. It keeps our spirit from growing weary. It shifts the atmosphere.

Practice: After intercession, spend time in intentional praise. Thank God by name. Sing. Speak of His faithfulness. Let praise complete your prayer.

Why Intercession Matters

To intercede is to stand in the gap. It’s to plead on behalf of someone else. It’s to say, “God, move here. Heal here. Act here.”

It is the work of:

- A priest – Representing people before God
- A warrior – Waging battle in the unseen
- A partner – Agreeing with heaven’s agenda

When you intercede, you may not always see the outcome—but you are always planting seeds. Always shifting atmosphere. Always partnering with the Spirit.

Divine Responses: Historical Examples of Powerful Intercession

While my own journey in intercession has taught me much, I find great inspiration in the testimonies of faithful intercessors throughout church history. Two examples stand out as extraordinary demonstrations of God's response to persistent prayer for others.

George Mueller: Praying the Orphans Through the Fog

George Mueller, the renowned 19th-century prayer warrior who established orphanages in Bristol, England, provides one of history's most dramatic examples of answered intercessory prayer. In his book "Answers to Prayer," Mueller recounts an incident that powerfully demonstrates God's response to specific intercession.

In the winter of 1877, Mueller was aboard the steamship *Sardinian*, bound for Quebec to fulfill a preaching engagement. As the ship approached Newfoundland, it encountered a dense wall of fog. Captain Joseph Dutton informed Mueller that they would need to significantly reduce speed, likely causing Mueller to miss his scheduled commitment.

Upon hearing this, Mueller responded with remarkable confidence: "Captain, I have never missed an appointment in fifty-seven years. Let us go down to the chart room and pray."

The skeptical captain reluctantly followed Mueller below deck. There, Mueller prayed a simple yet profound prayer: "O Lord, if it is consistent with Thy will, please remove this fog in five minutes. You know the engagement You made for me in Quebec Saturday. I believe it is Your will."

The captain, about to offer his own prayer, was stopped by Mueller, who explained, "There is no need for you to pray. You do not believe He will do it; and, besides, I have believed it, and He will do it."

When the captain began to express his doubts, Mueller responded: "Captain, I have known my Lord for fifty-seven years, and there has never been a single day that I have failed to get an audience with the King. Get up, Captain, and open the door, and you will find the fog is gone."

The captain opened the door to find, astonishingly, that the fog had completely lifted. Mueller arrived in Quebec precisely on schedule, demonstrating the power of specific, confident intercession rooted in relationship with God. (Mueller, George. "Answers to Prayer From George Mueller's Narratives." Compiled by A.E.C. Brooks, Moody Press, 1986, pp. 48-50.)

J.O. Fraser: Beyond the Ranges

James Outram Fraser, a missionary to the Lisu people of southwestern China in the early 20th century, offers another profound example of

intercession's power. In his biography "Behind the Ranges" by Geraldine Taylor, we find the story of a man who understood intercession as spiritual warfare fought primarily on one's knees. Fraser faced seemingly insurmountable obstacles working among the animistic Lisu tribe. For years, he labored with minimal fruit, battling intense spiritual oppression and isolation. What transformed his ministry wasn't a new evangelistic strategy but a revolution in his prayer life.

In 1915, during a period of particular discouragement, Fraser wrote to his prayer partners: "I am feeling more and more that it is the prayers of God's children that call down blessing upon the work, whether they are directly engaged in it or not. Paul may plant and Apollos water, but it is God who gives the increase; and this increase can be brought down from heaven by believing prayer, whether offered in China or in England."

Fraser developed what he called "prayer warfare," recognizing that intercessory prayer was not merely supplemental to mission work but the primary battleground. He established a small but dedicated prayer team back in England—mostly elderly women who committed to regular, specific intercession for his work among the Lisu.

What followed was remarkable. After years of minimal response, suddenly entire villages began turning to Christ. One of the most dramatic breakthroughs came when Fraser was actually away from his mission field. While on a necessary furlough, he received news that villages he had never even visited were destroying their spirit shrines and embracing Christianity. The specialized prayer team in England had been focusing their intercession on those specific regions during that exact time period.

By the end of Fraser's ministry, thousands of Lisu had converted to Christianity, establishing a church that continues to thrive today—even through the Cultural Revolution and persecution. Fraser's testimony reveals a profound truth: the most significant missionary work often happens not in visible ministry but in hidden intercession. (Taylor, Mrs. Howard. "Behind the Ranges: The Life-changing Story of J.O. Fraser." OMF Books, 1998, pp. 157-163.)

When God Confirms Intercession: Five Lives Changed

These historical examples are powerful, but I've seen the same principles at work in my own ministry. We had planned an outreach at a local park, and for weeks we had prayed specifically for people to respond and surrender their lives to Christ. On the night before the outreach, my friend had a remarkable dream in which five people committed their lives to Jesus.

The next day, we went to the basketball court and hosted the activities we had planned for the students we took with us, and invited other bystanders at the court to join in. There were probably 10-15 people that joined our group, and they listened attentively as we shared the Gospel with an invitation to respond at the end of our time.

I was amazed as exactly five guys raised their hands, got in a huddle with one of our leaders, and committed their lives to Jesus. We had prayed, God had told us what He would do through my friend's dream, we believed, and it happened precisely as He had shown us! I have seen this same pattern time and time again in intercession.

This experience taught me several crucial lessons about intercessory prayer. First, God sometimes provides prophetic confirmation of our intercession to build our faith and encourage our persistence. Second, the numeric precision—exactly five people, just as in the dream—demonstrated God’s sovereign foreknowledge and intimate involvement in our prayers. Finally, I learned that when we align our intercession with God’s revealed will and believe what He shows us, we participate in His redemptive work in ways that build both our faith and the faith of those around us.

Closing Charge: Join the Work of Heaven

These examples—from Mueller’s era to Fraser’s mission field to my own backyard—demonstrate the tremendous power of intercession transcending time, distance, and seemingly impossible circumstances. They remind us that when we align our hearts with God’s purposes for others, we participate in a divine work that can reshape destinies and communities. As we develop our own intercessory lives, we stand in a long tradition of believers who have discovered that conversing with God about others is among the highest privileges of the Christian life.

Jesus is interceding. The Spirit is interceding.

When you pray for your child, your city, your church, your friend—you are joining that holy work. You are stepping into the

rhythm of heaven. You are echoing the heart of the Son and the groans of the Spirit to a Father who hears and responds.

So discern His will. Anchor in His Word. Persist with boldness. Speak with faith. And seal it all with praise.

Because intercession is not just something you do—it's who you become.

A priest.

A partner.

A vessel for heaven's mercy.

Chapter 13: A Life of Ongoing Conversation *by Hannah*

Living Prayer as the Eternal Rhythm of Relationship

The miracle of prayer is that it is a never-ending conversation.

Over the last 30 years of my Christian journey, I have learned that when I direct my thoughts toward God throughout my day, He responds in ways that shape my steps. This book is a call to live in that awareness—to recognize that every conversation can be an opportunity to encounter God.

By understanding prayer as dialogue, embracing community, and engaging in deep conversations about and with God, we grow in intimacy with Him. Whether through silent meditation, verbal intercession, shared discussion, or private reflection, our communication with God shapes our spiritual journey. My hope is that this book has helped our readers experience prayer not as a duty, but as the natural and transformative conversation it was always meant to be.

“There is not in the world a kind of life more sweet and delightful, than that of a continual conversation with God.”

— *Brother Lawrence*

Brother Lawrence wasn't a priest, theologian, or public teacher. He was a 17th-century French layman—a former soldier who became a humble kitchen worker in a Carmelite monastery. And yet, through his ordinary life of peeling vegetables and scrubbing pots, he discovered something extraordinary: that every moment of his life could become a prayer.

He called it “*practicing the presence of God.*”

He didn't wait for a church service or a silent retreat to connect with God. He spoke with God as he washed dishes, served meals, or repaired sandals. Not with lofty words but with simple awareness. He trained his heart to turn again and again toward God—until it became second nature.

“The time of business does not with me differ from the time of prayer. And in the noise and clatter of my kitchen, I possess God in as great tranquility as if I were upon my knees at the blessed sacrament.”

Brother Lawrence's story became a small book—*The Practice of the Presence of God*—which has impacted generations not because of its

theology but because of its simplicity. He showed that prayer isn't confined to holy spaces or quiet hours. It's something we can carry with us—everywhere.

His life is a living example of what this book was about: a life of ongoing conversation with God.

This Book Was a Conversation

This book hasn't been a manual. It's been an invitation—to reimagine prayer not as a religious requirement, but as a relational rhythm. To view every conversation—as ordinary or as spiritual—as a space where God might be present and speaking.

We've talked about what it means to:

- Converse with God, not just at Him.
- Talk to one another in ways that reflect His heart.
- Listen, question, intercede, and surrender.
- Share our faith without fear or performance.
- Join others in sacred spaces of communal prayer.
- Let the Spirit lead us and shape our conversations with boldness and compassion.

And now, as we close, the invitation remains:

Keep going.

Live Aware. Stay Open. Talk Often.

The life of prayer is not for the “spiritual elite.” It’s for the parent doing dishes, the student walking to class, the nurse on night shift, the leader making tough calls, the one sitting in silence unsure of what to say, overcome with grief.

It’s for anyone who is willing to let their thoughts turn Godward—again and again and again.

Prayer can be:

- A whispered plea
- A journal entry
- A shared moment with a friend
- A scripture turned into a song
- A long silence filled only by breath and trust

It’s not the format that matters.

It’s the frequency. The honesty. The openness.

Because conversation with God is not just about outcomes—it's about relationship. This is how intimacy grows. Yes, there's value in scheduled, intentional prayer. But real transformation happens when prayer becomes a natural reflex rather than a spiritual task. We don't talk to those we love because it's on the calendar. We talk because it's how connection stays alive. The same is true with God. In Psalm 109:4, David writes, "*I am prayer*" (or, in some translations, "*I give myself to prayer*"). It's a breathtaking thought—that we might become so saturated in communion with God that prayer is no longer something we do, but something we are. A life so yielded, so relational, so open to God's presence that even our silence becomes an offering.

The goal isn't more prayer time—it's a more prayerful life. A life lived in the awareness that God is near, that He listens, and that He desires ongoing connection with us.

A Final Invitation

Whether you're worshipping in a crowded room or walking alone in silence...

Whether you're pleading for someone in intercession or simply sitting with your thoughts...

Whether you're sharing a coffee and talking about faith, or crying out in a hospital waiting room...

God is near.

Prayer is not limited by space, sound, or structure.

It is the language of relationship.

And relationship means ongoing conversation.

Let that conversation keep going.

Let it grow deeper.

Let it shape your inner life and your outer world.

Not out of pressure.

But out of love.

Because like Brother Lawrence discovered,
there really is no sweeter life than one spent in continual
conversation with the God who loves you.

Final Movement: *Further Up and Further In*

And yet, even after all these pages, we've only just begun.

Prayer is not a conclusion—it is an open door into eternity.

Let's step through one last time.

The miracle of prayer is not only that God hears us—it's that He
invites us into His eternal conversation.

The fellowship of the Trinity—Father, Son, and Holy Spirit—is not
a concept or a theological framework.

It is a living communion that stretches from *eternity past* and continues into *eternity future*.

It existed before the first light broke across the deep, and it will continue long after the stars have dimmed.

When we pray, we're not beginning a conversation—we're joining one.

C.S. Lewis offers a vision of this eternal fellowship in the final chapters of *The Last Battle*, where the old Narnia fades and the children are led into Aslan's country—into a new heavens and new earth. There, the curtain is pulled back, and they realize the deeper truth: all they knew before was only the shadowlands. The real story was just beginning.

"It is as hard to explain how this sunlit land was different from the old Narnia as it would be to tell you how the fruits of that country taste... This was the very reason why we loved the old Narnia—because it sometimes looked a little like this."

And with Aslan's beckoning, they go deeper:

"He turned swiftly... and led them towards the eastern door, further up and further in."

Each chapter of their story had been preparing them for this one moment: the beginning of the *real* story, the one without end.

“The dream is ended: this is the morning... the beginning of the real story. All their life in this world... had only been the cover and the title page: now at last they were beginning Chapter One of the Great Story... in which every chapter is better than the one before.”

This is more than imagination—it is theology in motion. It’s what Scripture whispers in promise and what prayer allows us to taste.

The conversation of the Trinity that called the cosmos into being in Genesis 1—the Word spoken, the Spirit moving, the Father delighting—did not end in Eden.

It did not fall silent at the cross.

It did not fade with the last page of Revelation.

That conversation continues, undiminished and unbroken.

And now, *we are part of it*.

When we pray—whether in whispered intercession, shared silence, sung worship, or quiet groanings too deep for words—we are joining a conversation that is *older than time* and will echo into *eternity*.

This entire book has been an invitation:
To listen again.
To speak honestly.
To walk with God in such a way that every moment
becomes communion.

Because prayer is not just a tool for spiritual growth—
it is the rhythm of eternal friendship. We will forever be talking to
the trinity.

So wherever you are—
folding laundry, driving in traffic, standing beside a hospital bed, or
journaling at dawn—
God is near.

The Voice that sang the stars into flame is still speaking.
The Spirit is still hovering.
The Son is still interceding.
And the Father is still listening.

And the invitation remains:

“Come further up, come further in.”

This is not the end.
It is only the beginning of the real story.

The Trinity talks.

And now, so do we.

Appendix: Conversation Toolkit: Talking About God with Clarity and Grace

Use this toolkit as a guide for initiating, navigating, and growing in spiritual conversations—whether you’re speaking with believers, seekers, or skeptics.

1. Conversation Starters

These are open-ended questions designed to invite spiritual reflection without pressure.

- “What’s been your experience with church or faith?”
- “Do you ever think about spiritual things?”
- “What gives you a sense of purpose or meaning in life?”
- “Have you ever had a moment where you felt God might be real?”
- “What do you think is the biggest obstacle people have with faith?”
- “Can I share something that’s really impacted me spiritually?”
- “What do you believe about Jesus?”

2. Practical Tips for Meaningful Dialogue

- **Lead with curiosity, not conclusions.** - Let questions guide the conversation rather than jumping to declarations.
- **Use “I” language.** - Share your own story: “Here’s what I’ve experienced,” rather than “You should believe...”
- **Listen twice as much as you speak.** - People want to be heard more than corrected. Empathy builds credibility.
- **Discern their readiness.** - Some are open to deep dialogue. Others just need a seed planted. Pay attention to tone and body language.
- **Respect the process.** - Salvation is often a journey, not a one-conversation event.

3. Common Pitfalls to Avoid

- **Talking too much.** - If you’re dominating the conversation, you’re not making space for relationship.
- **Getting defensive.** - It’s okay not to have every answer. Defensive energy closes doors.
- **Overcomplicating the Gospel.** - Keep it clear: God created us. Sin broke us. Jesus restores us. Faith reconnects us.
- **Trying to “win” the conversation.** - People aren’t projects. Stay rooted in love, not ego.

4. Phrases That Keep the Conversation Open

- “That’s a great question—I’ve wrestled with that too.”
- “Thanks for sharing that—I can see how that experience would shape your view.”
- “I don’t know the perfect answer, but here’s what I’ve seen in my own life.”
- “Would you be open to hearing a different perspective?”
- “Can I pray for you about that?”

5. A Simple Way to Share the Gospel (when the time is right)

Use this when someone is open and wants to understand what you actually believe:

- God made us for relationship with Him.
- Sin separates us—not just through bad actions, but because we’ve rejected God’s leadership.
- Jesus came to repair what was broken—through His life, death, and resurrection.
- Faith reconnects us—not through our efforts, but by trusting in what He’s done.

6. When the Conversation Ends

Follow up. Text them. Check in. Share a Scripture or a book. Let them know you're available for more conversation when they're ready.

Keep praying. God is often still moving long after the words have stopped.

One Final Reminder:

You're not responsible for the outcome. You're responsible for the faithfulness of your presence, your words, and your love.

Trust God to do the rest.